

RESEARCH-BASED STRATEGIES FOR EVEN BETTER PRESCHOOL STORYTIMES



Erin Ingram
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How To Use This Book

You work at a public library and regularly present a storytime program. You strive to meet the needs and expectations of children, caregivers, coworkers, administrators, and other community stakeholders. You want your storytime program to be both fun and impactful. Many of your choices are working well, but you wonder if there are any changes you could make that might enhance the storytime experience - for children, for their caregivers, for your professional development, for your library's mission and values.

But with so many choices to make, where can you start?

You've come to the right resource! This guide contains strategies that will help you enhance your storytimes based on the following:

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- Empirical research from the fields of early childhood education, child psychology, and library science
- Our original study of 68 storytime sessions presented at 35 libraries across three states
- Interview responses from 34 storytime librarians like you
- Survey responses from 346 caregivers whose children attend storytimes
- Survey responses from 698 public library directors

Think about an element of storytime you'd like to enhance, read through the Table of Contents below, and choose a path to begin your journey toward even better storytimes.

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2. **Why It Matters** explains the importance of the path's topic based on research articles from the fields of early childhood education, child psychology, and library science.
3. **What We Learned** reports relevant findings from our original research.
4. **What You Can Do** provides detailed strategies you can use while planning and delivering storytimes to increase your program's ability to help children build school readiness skills and to empower caregivers as their child's first teacher.

Important Note!

Virtual Variations: The research-based strategies we suggest are readily applicable or adaptable to delivering storytimes virtually, whether you'll be using prerecorded or live videos. Look for these *Virtual Variations* boxes throughout for tips on how to make these adaptations.

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- Reach more community members...
- Increase inclusion...
- Serve historically underserved families...

... journey to [Path 5: Strategies to Promote & Deliver Storytimes to Diverse Groups](#)

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1.1: What We Looked At

One way to look at how librarians may already be encouraging school readiness skills during storytime is to use assessment systems developed for early childhood education classrooms. We chose the Classroom Assessment Scoring System (CLASS) - PreK (Pianta, La Paro, & Hamre, 2008) because it focuses on a specific aspect of teaching also present in every storytime program: adult-child interactions. The CLASS focuses on the quality of interactions within three domains: emotional support, organization of the environment, and instructional support. As part of our study of how library storytimes can support school readiness, we used the CLASS to analyze the interactions between librarians and children in 68 storytime sessions across 35 libraries in Kentucky, Indiana, and Ohio.

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1.2: Why It Matters

Quality interactions have a positive influence on children's ability to learn (Hamre et al., 2013) and can be the primary driver of development in both formal and informal learning environments, e. g., preschool classrooms and library programs (Rutter and Maughan, 2002). In over 200 research studies, children had better social and academic outcomes when they were in Head Start preschool classrooms with higher CLASS scores; in other words, when they had teachers who consistently engaged in high-quality interactions with them (Hamre et al., 2008). Research findings show the multifaceted benefits of effective adult-child interactions in the three CLASS domains:

Emotional support

Creating a positive, emotionally supportive learning environment can help lower children's stress levels, reduce behavior problems, and aid in children's social and cognitive growth (Hatfield et al., 2013; Mashburn et al., 2008; Williford et al., 2013).

Organization of the environment

Children tend to learn more and are better able to regulate their attention and behavior in learning environments that are organized and predictable, especially when consistent behavioral expectations are clearly provided (Emmer and Stough 2001).

Instructional support

Children's learning outcomes, positive behaviors, attention, and social skills are higher when they receive instructional supports such as a variety of cognitively stimulating activities, rich language, and quality feedback from adults (Williford et al., 2013).

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1.3: What We Learned

The 35 librarians whose 68 storytime sessions were observed in our study earned CLASS scores in the middle range for emotional support and organization of the environment. This is encouraging! In the emotional support domain, the librarians delivered storytimes with positive atmospheres and almost no negativity in the climate, an important achievement given that caregivers rate a child's enjoyment as a primary reason they attend storytime (Cahill et al., 2020). Librarians also demonstrated sensitivity and regard for the children's perspectives as they talked with and responded to children. In the organization of the environment domain, librarians encouraged efficient levels of productivity, minimized distractions and disruptions by setting clear expectations for children and caregivers, and included a variety of instructional learning formats. They engaged the children with many kinds of fun learning opportunities such as shared book reading, gross motor movement, singing, and interactions with props.

CLASS scores were in the low range in the domain of instructional support for the storytime sessions we observed. Librarians may be reluctant to see themselves as providing instruction out of the fear that doing so will make storytimes formal and rigid – “too much like school” in bad ways. However, there are ways to engage children's natural curiosity and to create robust learning opportunities that children and their caregivers also find fun.

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1.4: What You Can Do

Consider implementing some strategies based on one or more of the CLASS domains of emotional support, organization of the environment, and instructional support. Below are explanations of each of the CLASS dimensions in relation to storytime programming. You may notice some overlap and reciprocity among the domains and dimensions.

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1.4.2: Organization of the Environment Domain

1.4.3: Instructional Support Domain

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1.4.1: Emotional Support Domain

The emotional support domain focuses on what you can do to help children develop positive, supportive relationships with you and others, feel comfortable expressing ideas and emotions, and have an opportune amount of independence (Teachstone, n. d). The dimensions in this domain are positive climate, negative climate, librarian sensitivity, and regard for children's perspectives (Hamre et al., 2013).

Positive Climate

Four indicators signal a positive climate: relationships, positive affect, positive communication, and respect (Downing, 2013).

- Build **relationships** with children and caregivers by having social conversations, providing activities in which children and caregivers interact with you and with one another, and guiding children to help peers when small problems arise (such as asking a child to get tape to help fix a peer's torn coloring page).
- Promote **positive affect** by greeting those who attend storytime, showing enthusiasm for the books you're reading and activities you're engaging in, and frequently smiling and laughing with children. (You're likely already excelling at this!)
- Use **positive communication** by stating your expectations positively (see more on this in the Behavior Management section of the [Organization of the Environment Domain](#)) and by giving positive feedback. For examples:
 - Acknowledge a child's words – even if they are “off-topic” – with a simple affirmative word or phrase (Okay; I understand; That's good to know) or with eye contact and a nod or smile
 - Use a child's name when responding to their statement.
 - Repeat a child's short utterance as a complete sentence. (Bonus: this also models language, providing instructional support.)
- Show **respect** by using a welcoming, calm tone of voice, actively listening when children talk, making eye contact with children, using polite language such as “please” and “thank you,” and encouraging children to also show respect to you and one another in these ways.

Negative Climate

As you might expect, a negative climate is something you'll want to avoid because it indicates the presence of negative behaviors and interactions either between an adult and child or child and child (Downing, 2013). The most severe indicators of a negative climate are bullying, threats, and physical punishment. Other indicators include sarcasm, teasing, anger, yelling, and harsh voices. These can often be avoided by focusing on creating a positive climate, but if they do occur, direct communication is key. After correcting the behavior in the moment, try to talk with the child's caregiver after the storytime session to determine the cause of the behavior and create a plan to de-escalate if a similar situation were to occur in the future.

Librarian Sensitivity

Four indicators show librarian sensitivity: awareness, responsiveness, addressing problems, and child comfort (Downing, 2013). (Bonus: many of the practices listed here will also help with Behavior Management per the [Organization of the Environment Domain](#).)

- Practice **awareness** during planning by thinking through problems children and caregivers may encounter during activities and how you can avoid or work through them. Practice awareness as you deliver storytimes by deliberately pausing to observe children and caregivers, checking for understanding and interest.
- Show **responsiveness** by acknowledging children's emotions, offering comfort as appropriate, and assisting children individually when possible.
- **Address problems** effectively by responding in a timely manner and talking through the problems with the child and/or caregiver to reach a resolution.
- Build children's **comfort** by giving them guidance and choice in how to participate in various activities. You might also consider ways to provide comfort by softening the storytime space with rugs, curtains, a lamp, or cushions or other soft seating, contributing to a home-like atmosphere (Campana et al., 2020).

Regard for Children's Perspectives

Four indicators demonstrate that the storytime is designed specifically with the needs and expectations of children in mind: flexibility and child focus, support for autonomy and leadership, child expression, and restriction of movement (Downing, 2013).

- Show **flexibility and child focus** by planning multiple activities ahead of time so that you can choose among them based on children's interests and reactions. For examples:
 - If children ask for a different song or want to repeat a song or activity more than once – go for it!
 - If children show disinterest in a book or restlessness - it's okay to skip pages or simply stop reading.
 - Prepare a short song or action rhyme that can be done if the children get restless and need to let loose some energy.
 - Prepare a short song or action rhyme or breathing exercise to help children calm down.
- Similarly, **support children's autonomy and leadership** by giving children choices and inviting them to take the lead in an activity, such as demonstrating the movements for a song. You might also consider displaying children's artwork and craft creations as decorations in the storytime area which may give them a sense of ownership in storytime (Campana et al., 2020).
- Encourage **children's expression** by asking open-ended questions that allow them to share their thoughts, opinions, feelings, and experiences (Bonus: this also promotes higher order thinking and is related to concept development, which we discuss in the [Instructional Support Domain](#).)
- Provide appropriate **freedom of movement** by giving clear behavior expectations for each activity while providing accommodations and options if a child cannot or does not want to do the activity.

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1.4.2: Organization of the Environment Domain

Organization of the Environment refers to the extent to which the setting and interactions support appropriate behaviors, child engagement, and efficacious use of time. Acknowledging that storytime environments are different from classroom environments, here are some ways to adapt strategies in this domain to the storytime context. This domain includes behavior management, productivity, and instructional learning formats (Pianta et al., 2008).

Behavior Management

When you hear “behavior management,” it might call to mind classrooms and discipline, but behavior management definitely applies to storytime! Behavior management is an especially important element of organization because it decreases distractions while increasing the amount of time you, children, and caregivers can spend engaging in planned storytime activities and fun conversations. What’s more, behavior management in storytime is not just for the children but the caregiver participants, too, because purposefully engaging caregivers can help minimize disruptions such as cell phone conversation.

The primary strategy for positive, effective behavior management is to clearly state behavior expectations at the beginning of the program, directing your comments to the caregivers. Librarians Carrie Rogers-Whitehead and Jennifer Fay (2010) posit that caregivers should be primarily responsible for managing children’s behavior but will benefit from your guidance in how to do this. Explain to caregivers how they can participate with the children to increase the children’s engagement. As an example and possible starting point for creating a list of expectations, Ghoting and Pugh (2020) recommend librarian [Elizabeth Moreau Nicolai’s “Guidelines \(Rules\) for Storytime” post](#) on her Born Librarian blog.

Another way to facilitate appropriate behavior is by having caregivers sit with their children. Try maximizing engagement with a cluster seating arrangement (see the figure below). When children sit close to the reader or presenter, and when caregivers sit with their children, children engage more actively in shared reading and other storytime activities (Campana et al., 2020, Paciga et al., 2015). If you don’t already have adults sitting with children, try taking time as attendees arrive to directly encourage caregivers to sit with and participate with the children. Have some chairs or accessible seating available for anyone with an accessibility need. Seating can be a small change that makes an important difference in children’s engaged behavior!

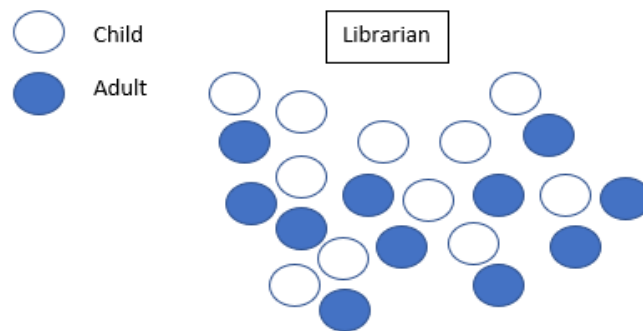


Figure 1.4.2.1: Cluster Seating Arrangement Example (Copyright; This Work)

Other ways to facilitate appropriate behavior involve being proactive. Some strategies:

- Alert children prior to transitioning from one activity to the next and remind both children and caregivers of expectations.
- Praise a child who is doing the expected behavior instead of correcting a child who is not. Behavior “problems” often occur because a child is not aware of the behavioral expectations or wants attention, so giving your attention to positive behavior both reinforces expectations and encourages attention-seekers to follow expectations.
- Phrase corrections positively, focusing on the behavior you would like to see (Ghoting & Pugh, 2020). For example, instead of saying, “Don’t stand up,” you can say, “Please sit on your bottom or stand in the back.” Thank a child for following a correction.
- When a child is repeatedly doing an unwanted behavior, give the child a choice between two good behaviors to do instead. You can also include why the wanted behavior is good. For example, if a child wants to stand up during the book reading, you might say, “When you stand up, the other children can’t see. So, you can stand to the side here [point to place] or you can stand in the back. That way everyone can see.”

- Librarians Rogers-Whitehead and Fay (2010) explain that giving praise, using positive phrases, and giving good behavior choices are important strategies because caregivers may be offended if you “discipline” their child or, as they may see it, single their child out for negative attention. Rogers-Whitehead and Fay (2010) suggest asking a caregiver to address behavior, such as asking the child to sit in their lap or, if needed, taking the child out of the area.
- It’s okay to ignore a harmless behavior, such as a child wandering around the room, if it is not distracting or disrupting (Ghoting & Pugh, 2020). Rogers-Whitehead and Fay (2010) advise that, especially for large storytimes with 30 or more attendees, “It is futile to expect everyone to be quiet; instead expect everyone to be *engaged*” (p. 9).
- If a child is especially disruptive or is not following expectations week after week, try to talk to the child’s caregiver immediately after the program.
 - Be as positive as you can while clearly explaining your behavior expectations and asking the caregiver to join you in making a plan for how to help the child choose more appropriate behavior next time. Emphasize that you want the child to be engaged in storytime.
 - You could also ask what accommodations you may be able to make so that the child can enjoy the program without disrupting. Asking the caregiver the best way to modify the environment to support their child will show that you want to include their child (Prendergast, 2015). Many children with special needs are labeled disruptive and asked to leave programs. This is a chance for the caregiver to share strategies and work to support their child’s inclusion in the group.
- Provide reusable name tags that caregivers can fill out for the children and themselves (Ghoting & Pugh, 2020; Rogers-Whitehead & Fay, 2010). Bonus: this will also help with building relationships and establishing a positive climate. If you notice a child becoming distracted, use their name before a comment or question to draw their attention back to the reading or activity. Children may be more engaged and less likely to choose inappropriate behavior if they know you are paying attention to them (Rogers-Whitehead & Fay, 2010).
- Use a call and response phrase to regain children’s attention (Rogers-Whitehead & Fay, 2010). When you say the first word, the children say the second word (e.g. I say, “story,” you say, “time!” “Story” “time,” “story” “time,” “story” “time!”).
- Make whatever you’re reading into an interactive book. For example, have children put a hand on top of their head whenever you read a certain word; listening for this word can be an extra incentive for attention, especially in large groups where children may be more easily distracted (Rogers-Whitehead & Fay, 2010).
- Decide some routines you will repeat and teach to caregivers and children (Ghoting & Pugh, 2020). Using the same opening song and closing song can be helpful. Additionally, you might provide a signal before you read each book such as a quiet rhyme or a hand puppet that introduces the book (Ghoting & Pugh, 2020).
- Plan your agenda with children’s attention spans in mind. Rogers-Whitehead & Fay (2010) suggest these guidelines for the order of activities:

Start with your longest book and move toward the easiest or most fun book, with some kind of fingerplay or song in between each title. Ending with a pop-up book, a flannel-board story, a story with large props, or one told with puppets is a great way to capture the last dregs of their attention spans. (10)

For more ideas for effective agendas, read the next section on Productivity.

- Flexibility can be just as important as a well-planned agenda. In response to children’s moods, interests or energy levels, it’s okay to skip pages or stop reading a book (Rogers-Whitehead & Fay, 2010). See the section on Regard for Children’s Perspectives in the [Emotional Support Domain](#) for more ideas about flexibility.
- Before responding to misbehavior, consider whether your involvement will help or only exacerbate the issue.

Productivity

Productivity refers to the ways in which you prepare for and manage time, routines, and transitions. Even though productivity per se isn’t a goal of storytime (you and the children aren’t trying to “produce” or create a “product”), strategies for encouraging productivity help ensure that time is spent wisely and are therefore beneficial to children’s enjoyment and engagement.

Consider how you handle transitions from one activity to the next. It may be helpful to add a song or rhyme to signal to children what activity is coming next and what behavior is expected during that activity. Visual cues, such as posters or a visual schedule, are another helpful strategy for transitions that may be especially beneficial for children with developmental delays or sensory differences.

It may be helpful to create a schedule or agenda for activities so that while the content of the activities may vary every session, the order of activities remains the same. Here is an example schedule from a family storytime at Vancouver Public Library (de Freitas & Prendergast, 2015):

- Welcome songs
- Two fingerplays
- A book
- Two action songs
- Middle item - oral storytelling, flannel board story, egg-shaker song, story with puppets, presentation/modeling of an educational app
- Two poems/songs/rhymes
- A shorter book
- Two calming-down songs
- Goodbye song

Another key aspect of productivity involves preparing the physical environment and needed materials. Before the storytime session, set up the room or designated area so that you have easy, quick access to whatever materials or technology you will use in every activity. Taking time to “set the stage” allows for smooth transitions and maximum engagement with children and caregivers.

Instructional Learning Formats

Don’t let the lengthy label turn you off. This is an area where many librarians already excel! It simply means giving children a variety of opportunities to be involved in activities, facilitating and expanding engagement, and anticipating and responding to children’s interests. You likely already do this by including not just book reading but also discussions, singing, action rhymes, dancing, and maybe even flannel board activities, play time, or craft-making in your storytimes.

- For more strategies related to the instructional learning formats of songs and movement, read [Path 3: Songs and Digital Technology](#).
- For more strategies for how to use play time as an instructional learning format, read section [4.4.2 Caregiver Goal - Children Socializing](#).
- For more ideas for adapting instructional learning formats to be inclusive of children with differing abilities and cognitive development, read the Families of Children with Differing Abilities or Cognitive Differences section in [5.4.2: Improve Support for Historically Underserved Groups](#).

Another aspect of this dimension involves clarity of learning objectives which simply means making the purpose of an activity clear. Explicitly connect each activity or component of storytime with what participants will be able to know and do during or after engaging in the activity. For each storytime component, explain the “what” and “why” before beginning the activity and then summarize after the activity is finished. Consider adding objectives to your visual schedule of planned activities to remind yourself to talk about the objectives as you transition into and out of each activity. In addition to the Office of Head Start’s Early Learning Outcomes Framework (summarized in the [4.4.3: Caregiver Goal- School Readiness](#) section of Path 4), two resources for choosing learning objectives and connecting them to storytime activities are:

- Public Library of Youngstown and Mahoning County’s Implementation Guides - <https://www.libraryvisit.org/kids/resources-for-librarians/> - detailed lists of storytime activities for supporting school readiness, broken down by the five early learning domains and by ages
- Saroj Ghoting’s Early Literacy Planning Tool based on Every Child Ready to Read (ECRR) - <https://static1.squarespace.com/static/531bd3f2e4b0a09d95833bfc/t/5b62929b1ae6cf5b12556cc2/1533186717601/6ELPT71518nool.pdf> - for each of ECRR’s six literacy components (phonological awareness, print awareness, print motivation, background knowledge, letter knowledge, and vocabulary) this guide provides storytime practices that a librarian may do with corresponding behaviors children may demonstrate, organized by age level

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1.4.3: Instructional Support Domain

Even though your storytime isn't a classroom and you won't be giving formal instruction, you can borrow some key ideas from the Instructional Support CLASS domain to enrich your conversations and support children's early literacy and school readiness skills. Interactions are the key means to support learning in the early years. The quality of instructional support in early childhood has been linked with later academic success (Hamre & Pianta, 2005); thus, modeling of strategies and explanations to caregivers regarding instructional support could be especially beneficial as caregivers are children's first teachers. Three supports identified by the CLASS are concept development, quality feedback, and language modeling (Pianta et al., 2008). Here are some suggestions for including these supports as part of shared reading discussions during your storytime. Planning is the key to improvement in this domain. We know that planning time can be hard to come by, but it is worth the effort for the benefits to your storytime attendees.

Virtual Variations: Interactions

Suggestions: You will notice that all of the strategies in this domain are based on interactions with children and/or caregivers. If you are doing a virtual storytime live in which children and/or caregivers can give verbal or written responses in real time, plan out time to include these educationally important interactions. If you are doing a prerecorded video, you can still harness many of the benefits of an instructional support strategy by saying the question, comment, or suggestion and then pausing for at least 5 seconds as though listening to and/or watching a response.

Support: A recent study found that preschool age children performed equally well on measures of reading comprehension and vocabulary when they experienced a dialogic shared reading of a picturebook in person, via video chat, or watching a prerecorded video (Gaudreau et al., 2020). A reason all three formats led to equal growth may have been that in every format the reader asked questions and made comments that encouraged children to think and respond, encouraging children to be active and engaged (Gaudreau et al., 2020). **These findings suggest children can reap the benefits of your selected strategies from the instructional support domain during a virtual storytime!**

Concept Development

The purpose of concept development is to promote critical thinking and higher-order thinking such as identifying cause and effect, making predictions, and problem solving. To facilitate concept development, involve children in analysis and reasoning by comparing and contrasting objects or events; encourage creativity through brainstorming or planning; link concepts and activities to one another and to prior knowledge; and help bring concepts to life by asking children to make connections with reading content.

A tried-and-true method for supporting concept development is engaging in conversation before, during, and after reading a book. You can elevate the level of the conversation through carefully planning questions and other strategies. Here are some strategies to consider:

- Start with lower demand, close-ended questions that have only one correct answer (Who? What?) and gradually scaffold up to asking higher demand, open-ended questions that may have multiple answers (Why? How?).
- Ask how, why, or "what if" questions.
 - How did the character solve the problem?
 - Why did the character do that?
 - What if the character did ____; what might happen?
- Ask questions that incorporate complex vocabulary words from the book.
- Use think-alouds – (i.e., explain your thought processes out loud).
 - After asking children what might happen next in a story, give your own guess and explain how you are basing your guess on an earlier detail from the story.
 - Explain how a detail in an illustration helped you infer a character's emotion.
- Guide children to share their own think-alouds, explaining the thought process they used to come up with an answer to a previous question.

Conversing after reading may be an especially fruitful time to engage children in making some of the three types of connections that build children's concept development: text-to-self, text-to-text, and text-to-world.

- A text-to-self connection asks children to relate a story element to their own experiences or opinions.

- Elephant is grumpy. What is something that makes you feel grumpy?
- They're going to the park. Raise your hand if you've been to a park. What did you see at the park?
- A text-to-text connection asks children to compare and contrast a story element to something similar in another text such as a book, song, or movie.
 - The elephant and his friends worked together to cheer up Giraffe. Can you think of another story in which friends work together?
 - How is the spider in "Itsy Bitsy Spider" like the engine in *The Little Engine that Could*?
- A text-to-world connection asks children to associate a story element with a current event or general knowledge about the world.
 - This story is called *If I Had a Sloth*. Raise your hand if you want to tell me one thing you know about sloths.
 - They celebrated Thanksgiving with a parade. What else do people do to celebrate Thanksgiving?

Spotlight on Wait Time!

The Strategy

When you ask an open-ended question about a story, do you want...

- ... children to respond with more than one word?
- ... more than one or two children to be ready to answer?
- ... children's answers to be thoughtful and accurate?

If you answer yes to any of the above, try this: **wait 5 seconds** (at least) after you ask a question before calling on a child to respond.

The Reasoning

A simple strategy that can transform the quality of your interactions in every domain is choosing a longer wait time after you ask an open-ended question. In our observations of 35 librarians, we found that many waited only 1 or 2 seconds for a child to respond before they began to answer the question themselves, asked another question, or returned to reading the text. It's understandable that adults are inclined toward rapid-fire conversation; one study of adults' conversations in 10 languages found that adults take an average of 200 milliseconds to respond to a question (Rezmer et al., 2020). Comparatively, studies of wait time in early childhood and elementary classrooms have found that **when adults extend wait times to 3-5 seconds, children are more likely to give longer, complex, thoughtful answers and are less likely to respond with "I don't know"** (Hindman et al., 2019; Rezmer et al., 2020). When children are given adequate time to think, they can engage higher-order reasoning, practice new vocabulary, and use more complex language (Hindman et al., 2019).

Troubleshooting Tips

- Experiment with wait times from 5-15 seconds, observing and reflecting on the number and nature (complexity, thoughtfulness, length) of the responses different times elicit.
- Help children wait for others and listen to others by talking about how to be an active listener with their eyes, ears, and closed mouth. Use a prop such as a doll or picture of a face to set expectations before and during shared reading discussions. Use a silent gesture such as pointing to your ears to remind children of the active listening expectation.
- Give children time to adjust to the new wait time routine. It may take several sessions to run smoothly.

Quality Feedback

Through quality feedback, librarians encourage and facilitate discussion. The purpose of quality feedback is to encourage, affirm, and give intentional responses to children's statements in order to encourage children to think more deeply or critically about the topic, increasing their understanding and participation (Pianta et al., 2008). While quality trumps quantity in terms of feedback, quality feedback may lead to an increase in the amount of time children spend talking - and that is a good thing! Talking about a topic helps reinforce learning and offers an opportunity for children to practice new vocabulary learned in association with the topic (Horst, Stewart, & True, 2019). An important element of quality feedback is making your responses *contingent* on what the child says. Make your response contingent by responding soon after the child talks and staying on the topic the child chooses (Gaudreau et al., 2020).

A useful way to increase quality feedback is to use the "**Strive for 5**" feedback loops strategy suggested by Horst, Stewart, and True (2019). This strategy includes multiple steps. You begin a **Strive for 5** feedback loop by asking an open-ended question. The ideal open-ended question is one that encourages the child to think deeply and share their thoughts, feelings, and/or opinions. After

a child or children give an initial response, you then use a follow-up comment or question to encourage the children to talk again, building on those initial ideas. Continue making comments or questions to help children stretch their thinking. The goal is to get five or more adult-child or child-child interactions in the loop. **Strive for 5** feedback loops can help improve children's comprehension, attention spans, and understanding that questions can have more than one appropriate answer (Horst et al., 2019).

Here are some ways to “**Strive for 5**” with examples from a hypothetical shared reading discussion:

- Recast the child's short answer into a sentence.
 1. Librarian: What do you see in this picture?
 2. Child: Dog.
 3. Librarian: Yes, the black dog is sitting on the porch.
 4. Child: They got a ball.
 5. Librarian: The children are playing with a ball.
- Extend the child's answer by adding details about the topic.
 1. Librarian: What do you see in this picture?
 2. Child: Dog.
 3. Librarian: Yes, the black dog is sitting on the porch. He looks like he's happy watching the children play.
 4. Child: They got a ball.
 5. Librarian: The children are playing with a ball. It looks like a soccer ball because it's black and white, and they're kicking it with their feet.
- Ask the child to add a detail.
 1. Librarian: What do you see in this picture?
 2. Child: Dog.
 3. Librarian: What is the dog doing?
 4. Child: Sitting.
 5. Librarian: Where is he sitting?
 6. Child: Outside.
 7. Librarian: The dog is sitting outside, very good.
- Ask the child to explain their reasoning after they give an answer.
 1. Librarian: Does the dog look happy or sad?
 2. Children: Happy.
 3. Librarian: Why do you think he looks happy?
 4. Child: He's smiling.
 5. Child: He wags his tail.
- Ask a follow-up question that encourages a connection between the story or activity and a previous story or activity.
 1. Librarian: Where is the dog sitting?
 2. Child: Outside.
 3. Child: On the porch.
 4. Librarian: He's on a porch. In our last story we saw a grandma and grandpa sitting on a porch. What did they like to do on the porch?
 5. Child: They drink tea.
 6. Child: Rocking chairs.
 7. Librarian: Yes, grandma and grandpa liked to sit in their rocking chairs and drink tea. The dog in this book also likes to sit on the porch.
- Ask a follow-up question that encourages a connection between the story or activity to the child's life.
 1. Librarian: What are the children doing?
 2. Child: Playing.

3. Child: Kicking a ball.
4. Librarian: Yes, they're playing and kicking a ball. They're playing soccer. What other games do you like to play outside?
5. Child: Tag!
6. Child: Hide-and-seek.
7. Librarian: Do you use a ball when you play tag?
8. Children: No.

Concept Development and Quality Feedback in Large Groups: Involve Caregivers

If your storytime regularly attracts more than 10 children, you may be wondering how you can apply any of these tips for concept development and quality feedback because it isn't feasible for you to interact with each child one-on-one during a 20-30 minute storytime session. You can achieve the same benefits if you involve caregivers in your interaction strategies. This works with any size group, but is especially important for large groups.

A key first step to encourage caregiver interactions is to arrange seating and ask caregivers to sit with their children throughout the storytime session.

Explain at the beginning and throughout that children get the most enjoyment and the most learning out of storytime activities when caregivers participate along with them.

Another key step is to plan the open-ended questions you will ask and the explanations you will give for how to have discussions around those questions. Explain to the children and caregivers that when you ask a question, you want the child to talk to the caregiver to give an answer. This way every child can have a skill-building interaction and caregivers can also practice giving quality feedback. Encourage caregivers to let the child do most of the talking by asking questions meant to extend or build on the child's ideas. Give suggestions for follow-up questions caregivers can ask.

Here's what this might look like in a storytime:

Librarian: The end. That was "What To Do with a Box" by Jane Yolen and Chris Sheban. Those kids had a lot of ideas for how to play with a box, and I bet you do, too. So now we're going to have a discussion. When I say, "Go," I want the children to turn to their caregivers and answer the question, "What would you like to do with a box?" We'll try to keep the discussion going for 3 minutes. Caregivers, we know that talking helps your child develop language and vocabulary skills. So, to help your child do most of the talking during these three minutes, try giving them feedback, like asking a question about what they're saying. You might ask, "How would you do that?" or "What else?" or "Why?" The goal is to encourage your child to talk about the topic, what they'd do with a box, for the whole three minutes. Ready? Go!

Involving caregivers in quality feedback not only helps children learn during storytime but also helps caregivers learn conversational strategies that they can continue to use as they interact with their children at home.

Language Modeling

Every interaction you have with a child is a chance to model language with the purpose of encouraging the child to understand and use varied vocabulary and sophisticated sentences. Language skills are an important component of both early literacy and school readiness because language skills prepare children to learn to read, understand classroom instruction, and communicate with peers and adults (Office of Head Start, 2015; Spencer, Goldstein & Kaminski, 2012). The strategies directed at Concept Development and Quality Feedback are likely to also promote Language Modeling, but language is so important that we offer additional targeted strategies to add to the language modeling you're likely already doing during storytimes.

As indicated earlier within the context of Quality Feedback, quality trumps quantity, yet one of the best ways to model language is to promote frequent conversations.

Self-Talk or Parallel Talk

Self-talk is narrating your own actions; parallel talk involves narrating the actions of another (Croasdale, 2014). Two key aspects of self-talk and parallel talk are that the talk is about an *observable action* and that the talk happens *at the same time* as the action (Croasdale, 2014). Self-talk or parallel talk can be especially useful strategies for language modeling during transitions between activities or during independent activities such as a play time or craft-making time.

Self-talk example: I'm passing out instruments for our next song. I'm giving you a blue drum.

Parallel talk example: Oh look, Juan chose all green blocks while Therese has red, blue, and yellow ones. Isn't it wonderful that everyone chooses differently?

Directly Teach Vocabulary by Selecting Teachable Words

You might be wondering – isn't shared reading enough? Maybe you've heard the idea that young children whose caregivers read aloud more books to them or elementary-aged children who read more books have higher vocabulary levels than children who are read to or read fewer books. While there is some evidence to support the idea that more reading equals more word knowledge, there is even stronger evidence that direct vocabulary instruction is the most effective strategy for increasing a child's vocabulary (Horst et al., 2019; Spencer et al., 2012; Snell, Hindman, & Wasik, 2015; Thoren, 2016). Direct vocabulary instruction has three main components: state the word, give a definition of the word using common words children likely already know, and give a connected example of the word's use - an example related to children's experiences (Snell et al., 2015).

Spencer, Goldstein, and Kaminski (2012) give advice for selecting the types of vocabulary words that are most easily teachable to preschool-aged children. Here are some types of teachable words:

- Word whose meaning can be defined with a synonym or antonym that is a commonly used word or with a short phrase made up of words familiar to most children
- Word with a variety of child-friendly examples; i. e., a word that can be used in everyday situations, routines, conversations, etc.
- Noun that can be taught by showing the real object or a miniature version
- Verb that can be taught by showing an action or doing a gesture
- Word that can be taught using easily understood information from the book you're reading, such as a story event, an illustration, or repeated use in the text

Using direct vocabulary instruction comes with a note of caution along the lines of the "too much of a good thing is a bad thing" adage. Some studies have shown that it is possible for adults to use instructional talk in ways that lead to less vocabulary growth in children (Hadley & Dickinson, 2019). Luckily, these studies also indicate ways to avoid this negative effect (Hadley & Dickinson, 2019). One way is to tailor your instructional talk to the children's current language level, which you can do by following Spencer and colleagues' (2012) guidelines for selecting teachable words above or three-tier framework from Beck, McKeown, and Kucan (2013) below. Another way is to give children plenty of opportunities and encouragement to talk themselves; for examples, you might ask them to repeat a definition after you or to come up with their own examples of how to use a target word. For a strategy to get caregivers involved in encouraging children's talk, see the Concept Development and Quality Feedback in Large Groups: Involve Caregivers section above. Another way to avoid negatively affecting children's vocabulary growth with direct vocabulary instruction is to carefully choose words that will aid children's understanding of a story rather than detract from it. Similarly, giving direct vocabulary instruction before or after shared reading, especially the first time you read the story, may help you to avoid unintentionally disrupting children's understanding.

Directly Teach Vocabulary Using the Three-Tier Framework

To learn how to select the words from a book that you will directly teach to children by saying the definition and at least one example of the word's uses, try this three-tier framework based on word utility created by Beck, McKeown, and Kucan (2013). Tier One words are the most basic and frequently used words. These are words that children are likely to have already learned through everyday life conversations. Tier One words are common or easy. Tier Two words are those that are fairly frequently used and have utility in many situations and academic content areas. Tier Three words are the least frequently used words and typically are applicable in only one specific context or subject area (geography, marine biology, government, etc.). Tier Three words are too rare or difficult to target during shared reading.

Tier One words include useful target vocabulary for children who are English language learners (ELL) or dual-language learners (DLL).

Tier Two words are the most useful to focus on for an audience of native English speakers. They are especially helpful for preschool age children as part of their growing school readiness knowledge. If you think of this three-tier framework as the

“Goldilocks” approach, then Tier One words are too easy, Tier Three words are too difficult, and Tier Two words are “just right.”

Beck, McKeown, and Kucan (2013) offer this guidance for choosing Tier Two words from a given text:

One 'test' of whether a word meets the Tier Two criterion of being a useful addition to students' repertoires is to think about whether the students already have ways to express the concepts represented by the words. Would students be able to explain these words using words that are already well known to them? If that is the case, it suggests that the *new words offer students more precise or mature ways of referring to ideas they already know about.* [emphasis added]

Note that Tier Two words are not simply synonyms of words children may already know. Rather, Tier Two words represent a more complex or more precise, though similar, concept. For example, *demonstrate* doesn't only mean “to show” but “to show how to do something.”

Along with this guidance, Beck and colleagues (2013) suggest teaching Tier Two words that children will need to know in order to understand the main idea of the storybook or informational text you are reading.

Alternatively, if Tier Two words are not used by the author of the book you've chosen, you can choose and introduce Tier Two words relevant to the book. For example, in the popular picturebook *Hooray for Hats* (2014) by Brian Won, a grumpy Elephant receives a surprise gift of a silly hat that cheers him up, and he goes on to gift parts of the hat to a series of animal friends who are also grumpy, thereby, cheering them up. During or after reading, you might introduce the word *distribute* to describe the action and *absurd* to describe the hat. You could explain:

- Elephant distributed the hat to his friends. Distribute means to give out many parts of something to each member of a group. Elephant distributed his silly hat because he gave out different parts to more than one of his friends. If he had just shared the whole hat with one friend, that would not be distributing. He distributed the hat by giving out parts of it.
- Wow! This hat isn't just silly, it's absurd. Do you know what absurd means? You can use absurd for something that is out of place and doesn't seem to have a reason to be where it is. Elephant's hat is absurd! Do we know the reason Elephant got this silly hat as a gift? No, we don't. It doesn't have a reason to be there; it's absurd!

Beck and colleagues (2013) point out that choosing Tier 2 words is not a science but a judgment call, explaining, “The final decisions about which words to teach may not be as important as thoughtful consideration about why to teach certain words and not others” (37). There are no “right” words to teach, but there are words that may be easier and more helpful for children to learn.

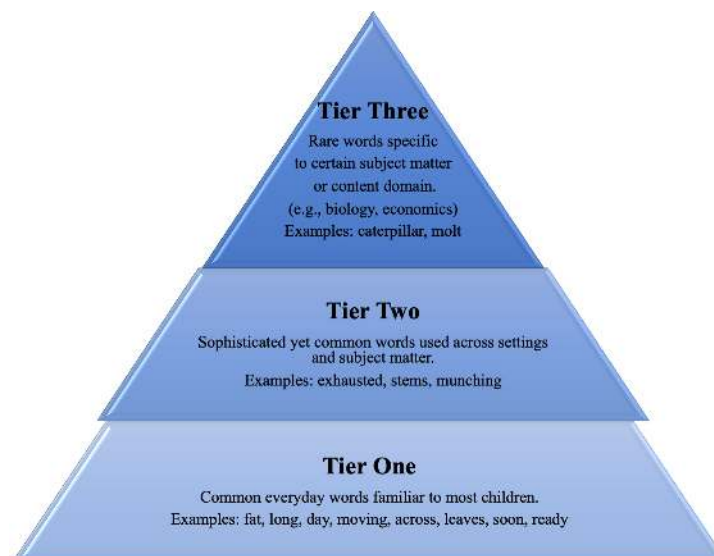


Figure 1.4.3.1: Three-Tier Vocabulary At A Glance. (Copyright; author via source)

Point, Act, Tell (PAT) and Push-In, Pull-Out (PIPO)

Along with using the Three-Tier Framework to choose vocabulary words to target, you can use the PAT technique to present the words (Rollins Center, 2021a). The PAT technique has three parts —**Point**, **Act**, and **Tell**. As you read, *point* to an illustration that corresponds with the vocabulary, *act* out the word through action, gesture, or facial expressions, and then *tell* the meaning of the

Tier Two word. Not only does gesture guide a child's visual attention but it also positively affects what they learn from the verbal communication - when gesture is accompanied with speech (Wakefield et al., 2018). When children are taught using both speech and gesture, they are more likely to learn novel ideas than with verbal instruction alone (Wakefield et al., 2018). The PAT approach can also be shared with caregivers as an aside so they are aware of this strategy you have applied in your storytime program and can easily replicate this tactic at home.

The PAT strategy also works in unison with the push-in, pull-out (PIPO) technique (Rollins Center, 2021b). You *push-in* vocabulary words when you use them yourself and *pull-out* vocabulary words when children use the words. One way to *push-in* is to directly teach a vocabulary word, such as by using the PAT technique. Another way is to use the vocabulary word when talking about the book or text. A way to *pull-out* a vocabulary word is to ask children questions they can answer by using the word. In addition to this, encourage caregivers to engage in meaningful dialogue around these target words outside of storytime so children are more likely to adopt and use these terms in everyday conversations.

Here are some examples of how you might use these strategies when reading the book *Peter's Chair* by Ezra Jack Keats with the target word *jealous*. You might begin by asking your young attendees, "Why did Peter bring his special things outside?" If children respond to the question by saying, "He was mad," you could try to *pull-out* the word *jealous* by using an either-or question (Do you think Peter felt jealous *or* did he feel happy about all the attention everyone was giving Susie?), a fill in the blank that gives them the first sound of the word (I wonder if maybe Peter felt /J/...), or a yes-or-no question (Do you think Peter felt jealous?). Follow up by restating their answer in a complex sentence: "I agree. I think Peter was feeling jealous of Susie. She was getting all the attention and he felt left out" (Rollins Center, 2021b).

Repeat Readings

Studies have found that children need to hear and discuss a book two to five times in order to learn new vocabulary from the book (Spencer et al., 2012; Thoren, 2016). You could choose a book of the month to read at the beginning or end of each session. Rereading a book also gives you the chance to try out multiple strategies for teaching the same target vocabulary. If your little attendees are consistent, they may be saying most of the book's words along with you by the third or fourth reading – and that's great language practice!

Here is a suggested sequence to introduce and reinforce selected vocabulary words with repeated read alouds of the same book (Horst et al., 2019):

- Read Alouds 1-4: For each target word, say the word, have the children say it, say the word with its definition, and then have the children say the word and its definition.
- Read Alouds 2-4: Review previously introduced words and definitions, and then introduce two or three more words and definitions.
- Read Alouds 2-5: Ask the children to say memorable words or phrases from the book along with you.
- Read Alouds 2-5: Ask the children to think about a detail they remember from the story, pair up with a peer or their accompanying caregiver, and share the detail, using a vocabulary word if they can.

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

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2.1: What We Looked At

Equity, Diversity, and Inclusion in Book Selection

During the 68 storytime programs we observed at 35 public libraries, librarians shared a total of 160 books; the number shared at each storytime ranged from one to five books. We analyzed the text and illustrations of each book with a coding scheme (modified from Crisp and colleagues' 2016 study) that focused on seven aspects of diversity: (a) parallel populations; (b) categories of books; (c) gender of leading characters; (d) sexual identity; (e) disabilities, developmental differences, and chronic illnesses; (f) religion; and (g) language. For aspect (a), we coded books as representing one or more parallel populations if the text specifically referred to a character as belonging to a racial, ethnic, or cultural group that has been traditionally marginalized in the United States (e.g., African American/Black, American Indian or Alaska Native, Asian, etc.). For aspect (b), the book could be coded as one or more of these categories created by Crisp and colleagues (2016):

- melting pot: depicting characters with a variety of visible identities without expressly acknowledging difference
- social conscience: promoting acceptance/and or tolerance of diverse groups
- culturally conscious: purposefully representing the experiences of a character from a traditionally underrepresented or marginalized group.

For aspects (c) and (g), we analyzed the text of the book. For aspects (d), (e), and (f), we considered both the text and illustrations. Additionally, we categorized the books according to type of main character (i.e., person, animal, etc.) or subject for nonfiction books.

Book Content with a School Readiness Focus

In addition to examining the books used by librarians in the storytimes we observed, we examined a random sampling of recommended books from six popular online resources for storytimes: *Esther Storytime*, *Jbrary*, *MCLS kids*, *Silly Librarian*, *Storytime Katie*, and *Storytime Secrets*. Using Worldcat data for the titles, abstracts, and subject terms of 429 books, we used text mining techniques to analyze the books' key concepts, genres, topics, and emotional aspects.

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2.2: Why It Matters

Equity, Diversity, and Inclusion in Book Selection

Carefully selecting books that promote equity, diversity, and inclusion (EDI) is part of practicing a core competency from the Association for Library Service to Children (ALSC) (2020): “Demonstrates respect for diversity and inclusion of cultural values, and continually develops cultural awareness and works to address implicit bias in order to provide inclusive and equitable service to diverse populations.” ALSC uses explanations of equity, diversity, and inclusion from the American Library Association’s Office for Diversity, Literacy and Outreach Services (2017) which explains that equity “means increasing diversity by ameliorating conditions of disadvantaged groups,” diversity means “the sum of the ways that people are both alike and different,” and “[i]nclusion means an environment in which all individuals are treated fairly and respectfully.”

When you share books that promote EDI, you give children opportunities to experience books as both mirrors and windows (Bishop, 1990). Children deserve the opportunity to experience books as mirrors reflecting their cultural and ethnic backgrounds, family structures, abilities, and religious beliefs (Bishop, 1990). Experiencing books as mirrors may increase children’s interest in reading, reading comprehension, and self-esteem (Bulatowicz, 2017; Husband, 2018, Winkler 2015; Wopperer, 2011). Equally important, children can experience books as windows into the lives of people outside of their immediate community (Bishop, 1990), teaching them to understand, appreciate, and celebrate difference (Al-Hazza and Butcher 2008; Dyches et al., 2018; Van Horn, 2015) while helping them to build empathy and cultural consciousness (Ishizuka, 2018; Winkler, 2015). Children as young as 3 years old have been found to both express and act on stereotypes and prejudices, and activities that involve reading picturebooks have been shown to help even young children combat stereotypes and prejudices (Gonzalez, Steele, & Baron, 2017; Husband, 2018).

Book Content with a School Readiness Focus

Selecting high-quality books is an often-cited first step in preparing a storytime session (Diamant-Cohen & Hetrick, 2014, Ghoting & Martin-Diaz, 2006; Kociubuk & Campana, 2019), and many storytime providers turn to free, though informal, online resources such as librarians’ blogs to aid their selection. Therefore, it is helpful to investigate these resources to determine if their recommendations are in line with research-based best practices for book content that promotes school readiness. Researchers have found children’s learning grows in areas of school readiness, especially early literacy, as they are read informational texts (Kociubuk & Campana, 2019) or books with academic content such as alphabet knowledge and math concepts (Thoren, 2016).

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2.3: What We Learned

Equity, Diversity, and Inclusion in Book Selection

The lack of equity, diversity, and inclusion in the 160 books used in the 68 storytime sessions we observed was surprising and troubling. Out of the 55 books that depicted a person or people as the main character or nonfiction subject, only two (or 3.6%) portrayed a character from a parallel population. For the category of the book, only three were coded as social conscience (1.9%) and two as culturally conscious (1.3%), which is significant because books in these categories are more likely to promote the benefits of reading diverse books explained above. This set of 160 books were non-inclusive with none that featured a character with a chronic illness, one that featured a leading character with a cognitive difference, and seven that depicted characters with eyeglasses. Books that depicted diverse religious traditions and languages were similarly limited or missing.

Book Content with a School Readiness Focus

Textual analysis of the random sampling of 429 recommended books revealed that animals was the most frequent topic and fiction was the most frequent genre. Other prevalent topics identified in the findings include social life (represented by words such as friendship, family, mother, and parent), learning concepts (represented by words such as alphabet, letter, count, and color), and activities (represented by words such as play, swim, dance, and discover). For emotional aspects, we found far more positive terms (such as like, love, perfect, fun, and favorite) than negative terms (such as tired, trouble, and fear). This indicates books for children are primarily aimed at creating an enjoyable experience while sometimes giving children opportunities to learn about negative emotions.

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SECTION OVERVIEW

2.4: What You Can Do: Equity, Diversity, and Inclusion

The following sections include ideas for improving how you select and discuss books related to the seven aspects of EDI we observed in our study: parallel populations; categories of books; gender; sexual identity; disabilities, developmental differences, and chronic illnesses; religion; and language (please refer to [2.1 What We Looked At](#) for explanations of terms). Think about who attends your storytimes and who lives in your community. What mirrors and windows (Bishop, 1990) would you like to offer them?

Note: Although the sections of this guide are separated, the authors acknowledge that identity is complex and intersectional, meaning that categories (oppressed or privileged) of race, ethnicity, culture, nationality, gender, social class, disability, sexuality, and age are inextricably linked, shaping children's social identities and impacting their everyday life experiences.

2.4.1: Parallel Populations and Categories of Books

2.4.2: Gender and Sexual Identity [Family Structures]

2.4.3: Disabilities, Developmental Differences, and Chronic Illnesses

2.4.4: Religion and Language

2.4.5: Spotlight on Informational Texts!

2.4.6: School Readiness Focus: Approaches to Learning and Cognition

2.4.7: School Readiness Focus: Language and Literacy

2.4.8: School Readiness Focus: Perpetual, Motor, and Physical Development and Social and Emotional Development

2.4: What You Can Do: Equity, Diversity, and Inclusion is shared under a [not declared](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

2.4.1: Parallel Populations and Categories of Books

Sharing books that call attention to or emphasize multiculturalism by depicting the co-existence of characters who are culturally, racially, or ethnically diverse may be a useful starting point. Choose books in which the main and/or secondary characters are illustrated with various skin colors, facial features, hair styles, and clothing styles. Be careful to choose some books that celebrate diversity and difference rather than only sharing those that present a “colorblind” mentality, which can give the false impression that differences are unimportant or even problematic (Husband, 2018; Winkler, 2015). As an alternative to this colorblind mentality, practice cultural competence by actively looking for and sharing books that positively represent the cultural identities of your storytime attendees and communities served by your library. For example, you can read book reviews from journals, international publications, IndieNext Reviews, the Association for Library Service to Children (ALSC), or the online book lists recommended below.

A further step toward diversifying your book selection is to purposefully select books that intentionally represent historical and contemporary cultural experiences of a parallel population—an underrepresented or marginalized group, such as African Americans, American Indians, or Asian Americans. One way to find such books is to choose books that have won an award for representing a parallel population, such as the awards listed later in this section. Another is to incorporate informational texts, such as biographies, articles from children’s magazines, and/or information and multimedia from online sources, about important historical and present-day people and events related to a parallel culture. In order to consistently practice and celebrate diversity, these texts should be shared throughout the year, not only during designated times such as Black History Month or Hispanic Heritage Month (Naidoo, 2014).

Awards to consider:

- American Indian Youth Literature Awards, sponsored by the American Indian Library Association - <http://ailanet.org/activities/american-indian-youth-literature-award/>
- Américas Book Award for Children’s and Young Adult Literature, sponsored by the Consortium of Latin American Studies Programs - <http://claspprograms.org/pages/detail/68/Award-Winners>
- Arab American Book Award, sponsored by the Arab American National Museum - <https://arabamericanmuseum.org/book-awards/>
- Asian/Pacific American Award for Literature, sponsored by the Asian Pacific American Librarians Association - <http://www.apalaweb.org/awards/literature-awards/>
- Carter G. Woodson Book Award, sponsored by the National Council for Social Studies - <https://www.socialstudies.org/get-involved/carter-g-woodson-book-award-and-honor-winners>
- Children’s Book Council of Australia Awards - https://en.Wikipedia.org/wiki/List_of_CBCA_Awards
- Coretta Scott King Book Awards, sponsored by the American Library Association’s Ethnic and Multicultural Information Exchange Round Table (EMIERT) - <http://www.ala.org/ala/mgrps/rts/emiert/ckskbookawards/index.cfm>
- Jane Addams’s Children’s Book Awards, sponsored by the Jane Addams Peace Association - <https://www.janeaddamschildrensbookaward.org/>
- Moonbeam Children’s Book Awards - <https://moonbeamawards.com/41/winners>
- Mildred L. Batchelder Award, sponsored by the Association for Library Service to Children, for books originally published outside of the US - <http://www.ala.org/alsc/awardsgrants/bookmedia/batchelderaward/batchelderpast>
- Pura Belpré Award, sponsored by the Association for Library Service to Children and REFORMA (The National Association to Promote Library and Information Services to Latinos and the Spanish Speaking)- <http://www.ala.org/alsc/awardsgrants/bookmedia/belpremedal>
- South Asia Book Award, sponsored by the South Asia National Outreach Consortium - <https://southasiabookaward.wisc.edu/>
- Walter Dean Myers Awards for Outstanding Children’s Literature, sponsored by We Need Diverse Books - <https://diversebooks.org/programs/walter-awards/>

Online book lists:

- <https://americanindiansinchildrensliterature.blogspot.com/p/best-books.html> Debbie Reese, writer of the blog American Indians in Children’s Literature recommends “Best Books” written by or about American Indians or First Nations people, organized by publication year

- <https://thebrownbookshelf.com/2021/01/03/african-american-childrens-book-projects-best-picture-books-of-2020/> The Brown Bookshelf website, curated by Varian Johnson et al., provides recommendations for African American children's books
- <http://www.clrsig.org/nbgs-lists.html> - Notable Books for a Global Society chosen annually by a Children's Literature and Reading Special Interest Group from the International Literacy Association
- https://cynthialeitichsmith.com/lit-resources/read/diversity/multicultural/multi_biblio/ - Multicultural Children's and Young Adult Books by Cynthia Leitich Smith
- <http://dia.ala.org/content/free-program-downloads> - El día de los niños/El día de los libros (Children's Day/Book Day) Diversity Initiative
- <https://diversebookfinder.org/category/collection/> – various recommendations for high quality children's books about Black, Indigenous, and People of Color (BIPOC) characters published since 2002

Other online resources:

- More storytime tips – from librarian Leah Langby - <https://iflweb.org/diversify-your-storytime/>
- Search tool – find recently published children's books by categories such as diversity subject and aspects of the primary character indexed by the Cooperative Children's Book Center - <https://ccbc.education.wisc.edu/diversity-statistics-book-search/>

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2.4.2: Gender and Sexual Identity [Family Structures]

Diversity in the area of gender begins with being aware of the gender pronouns used for leading characters and deliberately choosing books so that characters with a mix of male, female, and non-binary gender pronouns and identities are represented as main characters throughout your storytime sessions. Also consider how gender roles and gender stereotypes may be depicted in a book's text or illustrations, seeking to be culturally conscious by choosing books that show characters who identify as male, female, and nonbinary enjoying a range of interests, activities, family responsibilities, and careers. These do not have to all be shared within the same storytime session; consider how you will integrate them throughout the year or course of your storytime schedule to promote inclusion.

The majority of the main characters in storytime books are young children or young animals, so it is developmentally appropriate that they do not express romantic attraction or relationships. However, the sexual identities of older, secondary characters such as parents, siblings, or friends may be depicted in the text or illustrations. These depictions are a way to represent diverse family structures, a topic that children are already aware of through daily life that can be discussed in developmentally appropriate ways while reading stories. By age 3 children notice and talk about others' physical attributes, including gender, while by age 5 they can understand differences in family structure and begin to talk about how others are different from themselves (Evans-Santiago & Lin, 2016). Books with diverse family structures, as well as discussions you lead around them, provide children with the knowledge and words they can use to discuss difference with openness and respect.

Awards to consider:

- Boston Globe-Horn Book Award - <https://www.hbook.com/?page=boston-globe-horn-book-awards-landing-page> (search-friendly list: <https://www.teachingbooks.net/tb.cgi?wid=46>)
- Stonewall Book Award - Mike Morgan & Larry Romans Children's & Young Adult Literature Award, sponsored by the American Library Association's Gay, Lesbian, Bisexual, and Transgender Round Table (GLBTRT) - <http://www.ala.org/awardsgrants/stonewall-book-awards-mike-morgan-larry-romans-children's-young-adult-literature-award>

Online book lists:

- <https://feministbooksforkids.com/category/picture-books/> – recommendations curated by topics such as “29 Children's Books About Female Scientists,” “10 Children's Books About Blended Families,” and “12 Children's Books About Gentle Boys and Men”
- <http://glbtrt.ala.org/rainbowbooks/> – recommendations from members of the American Library Association's Gay, Lesbian, Bisexual, and Transgender Round Table (GLBTRT), organized by publication year and genre
- <https://www.literacyworldwide.org/get-resources/reading-lists/childrens-choices-reading-list> - Children's Choices Reading Lists - sponsored by the International Literacy Association (ILA) and the Children's Book Council (CBC)
- <https://risefeministbooks.wordpress.com/current-book-list/> – yearly recommendations from Rise: A Feminist Book Project for Ages 0-18 (formerly the Amelia Bloomer Project), curated by ALA's Feminist Task Force and Social Responsibilities Round Table

Other online resources:

- Book reviews – for children's books with LGBTQ characters by Patricia A. Sarles - <http://booksforkidsingayfamilies.blogspot.com/>
- Search tool – find recently published children's books by categories such as diversity subject and aspects of the primary character indexed by the Cooperative Children's Book Center - <https://ccbc.education.wisc.edu/diversity-statistics-book-search/>

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2.4.3: Disabilities, Developmental Differences, and Chronic Illnesses

Share books with main characters living with disabilities, developmental differences, and/or chronic illnesses throughout the season or year, not only during certain awareness months. Choose books that portray characters with disabilities as dynamic, unique individuals and not as flat, stereotypical, or “weird” children (Dyches et al., 2018). Look for books in which strongly developed, likable characters with differences positively interact or work together toward a goal and those that accurately and sensitively convey the difficulties of living with a disability, developmental difference, or chronic illness without treating the individual as someone to be pitied or protected (Dyches et al., 2018).

For more strategies related to creating inclusive storytimes, read about facilitating storytimes for Families of Children with Differing Abilities or Cognitive Differences in [5.4.2: Improve Support for Historically Underserved Groups](#).

Awards to consider:

- Dolly Gray Children’s Literature Award, sponsored by the Council for Exceptional Children’s Division on Autism and Developmental Disabilities - <https://www.dollygrayaward.com/home>
- Schneider Family Book Award, sponsored by Katherine Schneider and the American Library Association - <http://www.ala.org/awardsgrants/schneider-family-book-award>

Online book lists:

- <https://www.intensivetherapyforkids.com/childrens-books-about-disabilities/> - recommended children's books with audience age level and plot descriptions curated by the creator of a nonprofit for children with cerebral palsy
- <https://www.littleparachutes.com/picture-books-library/> – recommended picturebooks for helping children understand their “worries, issues, problems, and milestones” such as Serious Illness, Acceptance & Inclusion, and Resiliency/adaptability
- <https://www.mrsdscorner.com/60disabilitybooksforkids/> – recommended picturebooks about disability and difference from a special education teacher
- <https://www.teachingvisuallyimpaired.com/childrens-books.html> – recommended children’s books with blind or visually impaired characters from educator Carmen Willings

Other online resources:

- Braille Tales - The American Printing House offers 6 free print/braille books a year for families with preschool-age child who is blind or an caregiver who is blind and wants to read to a preschool-aged child - <https://www.aph.org/kids-with-vision-loss/braille-tales/>
- Ebook library – Beneteck Bookshare provides a free online library for any student in a U.S. school with a condition that impairs their ability to read print books - <https://www.bookshare.org/cms/bookshare-me>
- Further learning – a curated list of books, articles, and blogs about increasing inclusion from ALSC member Renee Grassi - <https://www.alsc.ala.org/blog/2016/07/serving-children-disabilities-libraries-beginners-guide/>
- Search tool – find recently published children’s books by categories such as diversity subject and aspects of the primary character indexed by the Cooperative Children’s Book Center - <https://ccbc.education.wisc.edu/diversity-statistics-book-search/>
- Video resource - Signing Savvy offers a free searchable dictionary of over 10,000 words and phrases in American Sign Language - <https://www.signingsavvy.com/search>

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2.4.4: Religion and Language

Children's literature can lay a foundation for helping children become culturally competent citizens of both our culturally diverse country and our global society. Cultural competence is an increasingly essential skillset for the 21st century. Maria Rosaria T. de Guzman and colleagues (2016), explain, "Cultural competence is the ability of a person to effectively interact, work, and develop meaningful relationships with people of various cultural backgrounds. Cultural background can include the beliefs, customs, and behaviors of people from various groups" (p. 1). Thus, encouraging cultural competence can be part of promoting school readiness in the areas of social and emotional development. Consider how you can select and share picturebooks that champion the diversity of religious practices and languages in our communities and our world.

As children learn words and concepts for discussing religious beliefs, they build cultural consciousness which will help them to succeed in our global society in which many hobbies, careers, and other social interactions involve conversing and collaborating with people from diverse faith communities (Naidoo, 2014). An important step you can take toward improving diversity in this area is to share books about characters practicing different religions throughout the year, rather than only on holidays (Naidoo, 2014). You can present welcoming mirrors and educational windows (Bishop, 1990) into diverse religious traditions by carefully choosing picturebooks with characters who authentically practice various religions.

Increasing the language diversity of your storytime can be an improvement toward school readiness because it creates a welcoming learning space for children who speak a language other than English at home, builds children's cultural competence, an important social-emotional skill, and provides additional language-learning opportunities (Domke, 2020). One way to increase the language diversity of your storytime is to share a dual-language book, one in which the text is written in both English and another language. Some dual-language books, especially those written before the 2010s, privilege English or contain cultural stereotypes (Domke, 2018); therefore consider using one of the resources in this section to choose a dual-language book with cultural sensitivity. Another way to increase language diversity is to share two versions of a story, one written in English and the other in another language. If you are not fluent in the other language, you could choose a book on CD, an audiobook, or a read-aloud video from an accessible website such as YouTube. Alternatively, you could form a partnership with a community member – maybe even a caregiver who attends storytime – and have them read the text in their fluent language. Another strategy for EDI in the area of language is to share a bilingual book that has words or phrases from a second language, such as Spanish, integrated throughout the book. This type of book utilizes code switching by either providing the English translation or using the equivalent English word or phrase in a subsequent sentence (Chaudhri & Torres, 2021). For more strategies related to serving families who speak a native language other than English or families who are English language learners, see section [5.4.2: Improve Support for Historically Underserved Groups](#).

Awards to consider:

- Christian Book Award, sponsored by the Evangelical Christian Publishers Association - <https://christianbookawards.com/winners.html>
- Hans Christian Andersen Awards, sponsored by the International Board on Books for Young People - <https://www.ibby.org/awards-activities/awards/hans-christian-andersen-awards>
- Skipping Stones Honor Awards, sponsored by *Skipping Stones*, an international educational magazine - <https://www.skippingstones.org/wp/book-awards/>
- Sydney Taylor Book Award, sponsored by the Association of Jewish Libraries - https://jewishlibraries.starchapter.com/images/downloads/Sydney_Taylor_Book_Award/stbaallawardwinnersever.pdf

Online book lists:

- <http://www.childpeacebooks.org/cpb/Protect/antiBias.php> – recommendations from educator Julie Olsen Edwards, including representations of religions and world languages
- <https://www.ibby.org/awards-activities/awards/ibby-honour-list> – Honour Lists of titles chosen biennially by members of the International Board on Books for Young People
- <https://www.ibby.org/awards-activities/activities/silent-books#> - lists of wordless picture books from over 20 countries and strategies for how to share them with diverse audiences

- <https://kidworldcitizen.org/category/literature/> – recommendations from educator Becky Morales, including representations of religions and world languages
- <https://www.slj.com/?detailStory=muslim-representation-in-picture-books> – picturebooks with Muslim representation recommended by School Library Journal contributors Sara G. Ahmed, Mahasin Abuwi Aleem, Ariana Sani Hussain, and Hadeal Salamah

Other online resources:

- Ebook library - <https://bloomlibrary.org/> - free online ebooks searchable by language and topic
- More storytime tips
 - about creating a multilingual storytime program from librarian Dana Horrocks - <https://jbrary.com/multilingual-storytimes-beginners-guide/>
 - about creating Spanish and English bilingual storytimes from REFORMA: The National Association to Promote Library and Information Services to Latinos and the Spanish-Speaking - <https://www.reforma.org/content.asp?contentid=87>
- Reviews of books written in Spanish and English - De Colores: The Raza Experience in Books for Children blog by Beverly Slapin and others - <http://decoloresreviews.blogspot.com>

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2.4.5: Spotlight on Informational Texts!

The Strategy

When you look for a new book to share during storytime, do you want to find a book that

... entertains while increasing children's knowledge of STEAM – science, technology, engineering, art, and math?

... prepares children to use reading to understand complex topics in elementary school and beyond?

... encourages critical thinking and vocabulary development during discussions?

If you answer yes to any of the above, try this: **read aloud from a high quality informational text** during each storytime session.

High-quality elements to consider when choosing an informational text include (Baldwin & Morrow, 2019):

- Topic of interest to children – either a familiar topic you know your audience members will enjoy or a new topic you believe will intrigue them
- Detailed photographs or realistic illustrations
- Clear definitions of vocabulary words such as in text boxes or picture labels

Professor Nell Duke (2020), a literacy consultant for the informational-text-promoting PBS kids program *Molly of Denali*, offers these tips for effectively choosing and sharing informational texts:

- Choose a text that connects to other texts, songs, or activities in the storytime and intentionally talk about those connections. Consider reading the text (or parts of the text) more than once across multiple storytime sessions, reinforcing and expanding ideas. These strategies will help you avoid using informational texts in a disconnected, potentially ineffective way.
- Keep in mind that you don't have to read every part of the text, especially if it is an informational book. Choose a part or parts with relevant information and as you share the text, use a **think-aloud** to explain how you used text features (such as the table of contents or index) or the reading strategy of skimming to find the relevant part.
- As you plan, choose a purpose for reading the informational text. Before you share the text, explain that purpose to the children and caregivers. For example, talk about what questions you and the children have about the topic that the text might answer.
- As you read, use enthusiasm and expression just as you would with a storybook.
- As you read, allow time for interactions. Let the children talk to you, one another, or a caregiver about the text. If children stray from the topic, guide them back by asking how their idea relates to what they learned from the text.
- After you read, ask the children to talk with you or a caregiver about what they learned or what idea from the text they think is most important – and why.

The most important strategy for sharing informational texts is talking through how to read an informational text. Familiarize yourself with common text structures and text features of informational texts so that you can talk about them as you read. There are five common structures (Moss, 2004):

1. *cause and effect* explains the reason something happened or happens and/or describes the results of an occurrence. Words that signal the use of this structure include: if, so, because, in order to.
2. *compare and contrast* identifies similarities and differences between two or more topics. Signal words for this structure include: same as, alike, but, yet
3. *description* gives details about a topic so that a reader can understand its essential characteristics or what makes it unique. This structure does not have signal words.
4. *problem and solution* explains the components of a problem and its solution or possible solutions. Words that signal the use of this structure include: because, as a result, so that.
5. *sequence* explains the order in which something happened, happens, or is done. Signal words include: first, second, then, next, last, before, after.

Some text features that you can helpfully point out if they are included in your chosen informational text are a table of contents, headings, words in bold or italics, charts, tables, graphs, diagrams, maps, photographs, illustrations, captions, an index, or a glossary. You can briefly explain the purpose of the feature, how it helps the reader to read the book. Naturally, you would not point out and explain the purpose of multiple text features in a single storytime session - that would be one way to lose the interest and attention of your young audience (and maybe even their caregivers!). Instead, you might touch on one or two of these each time you use an informational text, focusing on those that fit within the overall purpose of sharing the text. For example, if you were using an informational text to show an image of a bat, you might identify and explain the purpose of the captions accompanying a photograph of a bat. Or you might explain how you used the table of contents or the index to find the image.

Here are some examples of how you might explain the purpose of some common text features:

- Table of contents: shows the main ideas of each part of the book and what page to find them on
- Headings: tells the main ideas of a section or part of the book
- Words in bold or italics: important words to know that have a definition given on this page and/or in the glossary

- Charts, tables graphs: show facts with numbers
- Diagrams: show something in detail to label the name of its parts (and explain what each is or does)
- Maps: show where something is in the world in relation to other things
- Photographs: pictures taken with a camera
- Illustrations: pictures made by an artist like a drawing or painting
- Captions: the words under or near a picture that give information about the picture
- Index: alphabetical list of topics in the book and what page to find them on
- Glossary: alphabetical list of important words and their definitions

The Reasoning

Informational texts, also known as nonfiction or expository texts, are written with the primary purpose of conveying information (Kociubuk & Campana, 2019). Informational texts may include not only nonfiction books but also posters, websites, audio recordings, or videos – as long as the purpose is to convey information (Duke, 2020). **Reading aloud from informational texts and discussing their special features (graphs, captions, headings, indexes, etc.) prepares children to read on their own in elementary school by familiarizing them with vocabulary, writing conventions, and background knowledge** (Kociubuk & Campana, 2019). Despite the benefits of informational texts in building these early literacy skills, studies have found that few books in this genre are read aloud either in preschools or at home, especially in the homes of families with lower economic status (Pentimonti et al., 2010; Robertson & Reese, 2017). Studies have also found that **children enjoy and are excited to talk about informational texts** (Kociubuk & Campana, 2019). As a storytime provider, you have the ability to share this genre with children and help close the knowledge gap!

Troubleshooting Tips

- If the time you can devote to discovering new storytime material is short, start with the goal of including one informational text in every fourth or fifth storytime and build up to every storytime as your personal collection of excellent texts grows.
- Keep in mind that you don't have to share the whole book or read every sentence on a page. Choose the ideas that suit a specific information need, you find most interesting, and/or think the children will engage with. Even sharing just photographs and captions is a great start to helping children learn about this important genre!
- Try sharing narrative informational books, such as biographies. These have narrative elements such as characters, setting, and suspense that children are familiar and comfortable with from storybooks along with informational text features such as photographs or timelines that you can introduce.
- For lists of high-quality nonfiction books, check out:
 - Carter G. Woodson Book Award: <https://www.socialstudies.org/get-involved/carter-g-woodson-book-award-and-honor-winners>
 - Jefferson Cup Award: <https://www.vla.org/jefferson-cup-past-winners>
 - National Science Teachers Association Best STEM Books K-12 list <https://www.nsta.org/best-stem-books-k-12>
 - Robert F. Sibert Informational Book Award: <http://www.ala.org/alsc/awardsgrants/bookmedia/sibertmedal/sibertpast/sibertmedalpast>

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2.4.6: School Readiness Focus: Approaches to Learning and Cognition

You may know, especially if you journeyed through [Path 1](#) in this guide, that in a way any book you share in storytime can support early learning because the interactions you have with children are the essential ingredient in children's learning. With that understood, it is also true that the content of a book can make it easier to create those quality interactions. As a librarian, selecting storytime books is just one of your many responsibilities, so you want to make it easier on yourself, right?

Here are some tips and resources for choosing and sharing books that will most naturally and readily support a variety of early learning experiences for your storytime children. These early learning categories are taken from a school readiness framework developed by the Office of Head Start (2015), which you can learn more about in section [4.4.3 Caregiver Goal - School Readiness](#).

Approaches to Learning

The Approaches to Learning domain encompasses a range of abilities and attitudes that may enable a child to succeed in the formal environment of a school classroom (Office of Head Start, 2015). These are managing emotions, following routines, handling materials with care, managing talk and behavior, controlling impulses, maintaining focus and attention, persisting in tasks, using remembered information to do a task, thinking flexibly, playing independently, showing curiosity, communicating creative ideas, and using imagination in play (Office of Head Start, 2015). In addition to practicing these approaches to learning as they engage in storytime activities, children – and their caregivers - may learn about them from picturebooks that depict characters demonstrating these abilities and attitudes. Sharing such picturebooks can also provide opportunities to talk with caregivers about how to help their child prepare for school.

In a review of empirical studies, Strouse, Nyhout, and Ganea (2018) identified some features of picturebooks that may help children to remember and apply information from a book to a real-world context. These features are:

- Pictorial realism – the closer the illustrations are to looking like the real world, the more likely children are to transfer ideas from the book to the real world.
- Realistic context – children are more likely to transfer ideas, such as problem-solving techniques, from a book with realistic human characters and possible events than from one with fantastical characters and events (e.g., talking animals or objects).
- Genre – children can understand the difference between a fictional book and an informational text and may more readily accept and apply ideas from an informational text. (For more on using informational texts to improve your storytime, read the [Spotlight on Informational Texts](#))

Strouse and colleagues (2018) concluded that even though book features are important, an even more important and effective way to encourage young children's learning is to have conversations with them about the book's content during and after reading. With that in mind, look for books that easily bring to mind questions and comments you can make to stimulate conversations about the approach to learning ability or attitude – persisting in tasks, playing independently, showing curiosity, etc. – that you want to highlight.

Cognition: Concept Books

Concept books are “informational texts that teach an abstract, foundational idea such as the alphabet, numbers, and colors through examples rather than topical explanations” (Domke, 2020, p. 23). Keep in mind that even when you share carefully chosen concept books, children make the most learning gains when you also carefully choose direct comments and questions about the concept to include during and after your reading (Bradley & Jones, 2007; Hindman et al., 2019). Here are some tips for choosing concept books that will help you facilitate discussions that build children's school readiness in the domain of cognition.

Alphabet Books. Some features of alphabet books may best facilitate discussions about letter knowledge, a key component of early literacy (Bradley & Jones, 2007; Deitcher, Aram, & Goldberg, 2018). These features are:

- Illustrations of things with a beginning letter sound that clearly matches the letter on the page
- Illustrations that encourage talk about how the same letter can make different sounds
- Small number of simple illustrations
- Target letters clearly differentiated from other letters on the page with different font size, color, or style

- Simply rendered target letters rather than letters that have been graphically altered to fit an illustration (for example, the letter C next to a picture of a cat is better than a C drawn with ears and a tail like a cat)
- A majority of words that are familiar to children - so that the focus of the discussion can be on the letter names and sounds rather than on giving definitions or building content knowledge

Counting Books. Concept books vary greatly in the style of their illustrations and how number concepts are presented (Ward et al., 2017). There is consensus that adults can and should use books to teach the very important foundational math skill of cardinality – the understanding that the number of items in a set is the last number said (Mix et al., 2012; Ward et al., 2017). The best way to teach cardinality is to label the quantity of the set and immediately count the same set, and then ask the children to repeat this label and count practice (Mix et al., 2012). For example: "There are five pumpkins on the fence. One, two, three, four, five. How many pumpkins are on the fence? Five, right. Can you count them with me? One, two, three, four, five." **The combination of labeling and then counting** has been found to be far more effective than only labeling or only counting (Mix et al., 2012). Therefore, choose counting books with illustrations of sets of items that can be labeled and counted.

Some **general concept book** guidelines:

- Simple illustrations may help children have better recall of the concept than complex or “busy” illustrations.
- Realistic illustrations or photographs may increase the likelihood that children will learn a concept, as compared to cartoonish or abstract illustrations (Strouse et al., 2018; Tare et al., 2010).
- Manipulative books such as lift-the-flap or pop-up books may actually impair children’s ability to learn the target concept if the manipulative elements are distracting (Chiong & DeLoache, 2013; Tare et al., 2010).
- Repeated words or phrases, as well as rhyming words or phrases, can help children recall key ideas (Ward et al., 2017).
- As with other informational texts, you can select a concept book with the intention of sharing only a few relevant or useful pages, rather than reading cover to cover as you would a storybook.

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2.4.7: School Readiness Focus: Language and Literacy

Language and Literacy: Book and Print Conventions

Book conventions are the general "rules" for understanding how to read a book such as the parts of a book (front and back cover, pages, spine, etc.), where to start reading, the direction in which to read, the contents of the cover (title, author's and illustrator's name(s), etc.), and text features such as a table of contents or an index (read more about these in the [Spotlight on Informational Texts](#)). Print conventions include spaces between letters and words, punctuation, capitalization, and varying text styles such as italics or boldface. An overall strategy for improving children's ability to understand book or print conventions is to choose a few to label during your storytime each time you come across them.

Studies have shown that young children spend very little time, as little as 2% of their total viewing time, looking at the words on a page during shared book reading (Evans & Saint-Aubin, 2011). To help build print awareness, you can use print referencing – pointing to target words as you say them, commenting on the way a word looks on the page and why it looks that way (such as larger or smaller words to show a character is yelling or whispering), or asking questions about the words or letters on a page (especially when sharing alphabet books). Print referencing during shared book reading may increase children's print awareness, a foundational concept for early literacy (Evans & Saint-Aubin, 2011; Terrell & Watson, 2018).

Some books lend themselves more easily to print referencing because they have higher print saliency, meaning more words or letters intentionally and noticeably stand out. To integrate highly print-salient books into your storytime, look for books with one or more of these print features (Terrell & Watson, 2018):

- Changes in font size or style for a purpose (for example: headings, character's emotions, target concept such as shape names)
- Print within illustrations
- Speech bubbles

Note that highly print-salient books *on their own* don't significantly raise the amount of attention young children pay to the words and letters on a page (Evans & Saint-Aubin, 2011), but rather they can *assist your use of print referencing* which may support children's development of print awareness.

For more strategies for choosing books that support this aspect of school readiness, take a look at literacy expert Saroj Ghoting's quick guide to choosing and sharing books based on the first edition of Every Child Ready to Read found at <https://static1.squarespace.com/static/531bd3f2e4b0a09d95833bfc/t/5497780ee4b07be310595fe0/1419212814946/ideasskillsbkchar2.pdf>.

Language and Literacy: Five Practices: Read, Talk, Sing, Write, Play

After in-depth research, the scholars behind the second edition of the Every Child Ready to Read initiative created a framework of five practices that children and caregivers can do together to promote early literacy: read, talk, sing, write, and play (Neuman, Moland, & Celano, 2017). These five practices can be incorporated into every storytime with any book, but you can give your storytime a boost by selecting a book particularly representative of one of the practices.

Colorado Libraries for Early Literacy (CLEL) has annually given a Bell Award since 2013 honoring five books, one for each of the five practices, that support or model each practice particularly well (Depper, 2016). You can find a list of winners here: <https://www.clel.org/bell-awards-winners>. CLEL includes an activity sheet with each suggested book that you can use to plan storytime discussions, group activities, craft time, or caregiver take-home sheets (Depper, 2016). For more lists of books that easily promote the five early literacy practices and are recommended by librarians, take a look at Waterloo Public Library's ECRR-inspired page: <https://www.wpl.ca/programs-events/Explore-Play-Learn>.

Language and Literacy: Phonemic Awareness

One of the most important early literacy skills a child can acquire is phonemic awareness, the ability to identify, differentiate, and manipulate the smallest individual sounds (phonemes) that compose words in any language (Fresch & Harrison, 2013). Phonemic awareness is a type of phonological awareness, which is a broader understanding that language is made up of sounds (Riordan et al., 2018). Children demonstrate phonemic awareness when they can identify rhymes and alliteration (identical sounds at the

beginning of words, e.g., *cool cat*), blend and split syllables, say the sounds that make up a word, or manipulate the sounds of a word to make a new word (e.g., change the /k/ sound in *cat* to the /b/ sound and say *bat*) (Fresch & Harrison, 2013).

One type of book that stands out as ideal for increasing children's phonemic awareness are books with rhyming text (Riordan et al., 2018). These can include collections of rhyming poems, especially nursery rhymes, as well as books in which the text is song lyrics. You may already know from experience and research has shown it – children love rhyming text! As you read, choose pages where you will pause to ask children to guess the rhyming words or to think of other rhyming words (Giles & Fresne, 2015).

Another type of book that you can use to build phonemic awareness are books with repeated words or phrases (Giles & Fresne, 2015). Encourage children to listen for the repeated word or phrase and vocalize a related sound or perform a related movement each time they hear the word or phrase. Provide a scaffold to this listening skill or an accommodation by using a hand signal to encourage children's participation.

Language and Literacy: Vocabulary

Choose books with three or more teachable words or Tier 2 words throughout the text that you can define and provide examples for. For more details on this strategy, check out the Language Modeling section of [1.4.3 Instructional Support Domain](#).

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2.4.8: School Readiness Focus: Perpetual, Motor, and Physical Development and Social and Emotional Development

Perceptual, Motor, and Physical Development

Interactive picturebooks create a fun experience and can also help children learn and practice school readiness in the domain of perceptual, motor, and physical development which includes coordination, fine and gross motor control, and following directions. Interactive picturebooks encourage movement with text that invites children to follow the movements of a character or to follow instructions that then appear to have an effect on the book's action (Pyrek, 2014). For some recommended interactive books to get you started, check out:

- “Participation Palooza: Creating a Festive Storytime Atmosphere with Interactive Books” by children’s librarian Jessica Pyrek - <https://journals.ala.org/index.php/cal/article/view/32/7>
- “Get Busy! Fun with Interactive Books” by *School Library Journal* reviewer Joy Fleishhacker - <https://www.slj.com/?detailStory=get-busy-fun-interactive-books>
- “Tell Stories Like a Rock Star–The BEST Interactive Picture Books” by children’s librarian and blogger Peter Blenski - <https://legolibrarian.com/2018/03/09/tell-stories-like-a-rock-star-the-best-interactive-picture-books/>

Social and Emotional Development

The International Literacy Association (2020) reports that many literacy educators believe it is their responsibility to assist children’s social and emotional learning along with literacy learning. Many studies have found that hearing children’s literature read aloud can assist children’s social and emotional development, especially when accompanied by discussions or enrichment activities, by giving children vocabulary to identify and describe emotions in themselves and others and by modeling emotional self-regulation, empathetic behavior, and other prosocial behaviors (Harper, 2016; Short, 2018; Thoren, 2016).

Children may more easily transfer social skills, such as problem solving, from a picturebook to the real world when the book has a realistic rather than fantastical context and realistic human characters rather than animals, monsters, or objects as characters (Strouse et al., 2018). Laurie J. Harper (2016) suggests these criteria for choosing picturebooks that promote social and emotional development:

1. Plot: contains realistic, believable, events that are relatable to children’s lived experiences across cultures
2. Characters: display a range of emotions consistent with story events
3. Illustrations: include facial features that match the emotions expressed in the text
4. Vocabulary: includes range of words to label and describe emotions
5. Visual style: uses elements such as color and perspective to evoke characters’ emotions and assist children in making connections between the text and themselves or the world.

One resource to consider is the Center on the Social and Emotional Foundations for Early Learning’s curated list of books related to topics in children’s social-emotional development (such as Being a Friend, Angry or Mad Feelings, and Good Behavior Expectations) available at: http://www.pyramidmodel.org/wp-content/uploads/2016/10/csefel_booklist.pdf. Another resource is recommended literature from Open Circle, creators of an evidence-based social and emotional learning curriculum, available at: <https://www.open-circle.org/resources/childrens-literature>.

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

Path 3: Songs and Digital Technology

3.1: What We Looked At

3.2: Why It Matters

3.3: What We Learned

3.4: What You Can Do

3.4.1: Songs and Movement

3.4.2: Digital Technology

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3.1: What We Looked At

Songs and Movement

The complexity and content of language that young children hear influence their oral language skills. Oral language skills, in addition to being a foundational part of school readiness (Office of Head Start, 2015), can contribute to later reading skills (Dickinson, Golinkoff, & Hirsh-Pasek, 2010). We know that children can hear high-quality language from the books shared during storytimes (Massaro, 2015), so we wondered if the conversations and songs during storytimes could also contribute to a high-quality language environment. Therefore, we analyzed the complexity and content of the utterances spoken and sung during storytimes. Additionally, we know that nonverbal supports such as gestures can facilitate children's vocabulary learning (Grifenhagen, 2012), so we wanted to look at how librarians paired movements or props with spoken or sung words. We created transcripts from the videos recorded at 68 preschool storytime sessions. Each transcript was divided into individual utterances. When analyzing spoken language, we use the term utterance rather than sentence because spoken language differs from written language in that there are not always clear breaks between sentences. An utterance is continuous speech that begins and ends with a perceptual pause. Each utterance was given a code for whether it was sung or spoken, for which participant(s)—librarian, child, caregiver— sung or spoke the utterance, and for whether the use of a prop and/or movement by any participant accompanied the utterance. We analyzed the relative complexity of the sung and spoken utterances. We also used content analysis to compare and contrast topics and concepts used.

Digital Technology

As we observed storytimes and later watched videos recorded during those observations, we took note of the types of digital technology used by the librarians and attendees. Digital technology could include a CD or tape player used for playing music; an iPod, mp3/mp4 player, or smartphone used for playing music; an iPad, tablet, or other handheld device manipulated by the librarian only; an iPad, tablet, or other handheld device manipulated by the children and/or caregivers; a television or projector used for playing a video; or a television or projector used for displaying information such as song lyrics or behavior expectations. We expected to see this kind of technology used in about half of the storytimes because in a 2018 survey of 262 library staff from libraries across the United States, participants reported that digital devices were used for storytimes in 45.74% of small libraries, 54.29% of medium libraries, and 69.23% of large libraries (Campana et al., 2019).

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3.2: Why It Matters

Songs and Movement

The complexity and content of the language used throughout storytimes is important because oral language development is a key component of children's early literacy (Neuman et al., 2017). The use of songs can increase children's phonological awareness and vocabulary knowledge, which are the building blocks of early literacy (Williams et al., 2015). Songs may be a particularly useful learning strategy because most children enjoy songs and pay attention to songs (Koops & Kuebel, 2018; Powell & Somerville, 2020) and because the use of props and movement along with singing creates an active learning experience (Hirsh-Pasek et al., 2015). Research has found that caregivers who attend storytime sessions with music believe that music benefits their children's engagement, enjoyment, and literacy (de Vries, 2008). These caregivers also repeat musical activities from storytimes at home, increasing children's opportunities for growth (de Vries, 2008).

Digital Technology

Digital technology has become prevalent in the lives of children and families across the United States. According to the Common Sense Census survey of over 1,400 parents with children ages 0 to 8, the percentage of families with a mobile device (such as a smartphone or tablet) in the home has risen from 52% in 2011 to 98% in 2020 (Rideout & Robb, 2020). Children ages 2-5 spend an average of two and a half hours per day using a device with a screen though only an average of 3% of that time (5 minutes) is spent reading an ebook (Rideout & Robb, 2020). This indicates that although many caregivers may have access to digital technology, they are not using that technology to increase children's learning from ebooks. When asked to rank the importance of reasons for a child's screen use, the reason "They learn things from it" was ranked as "Very Important" or "Somewhat Important" by 78% of parents in the survey (Rideout & Robb, 2020). The reason "For fun" was ranked as "Very Important" or "Somewhat Important" by 77% of parents (Rideout & Robb, 2020). As librarians, we know that reading ebooks can be both educational and fun, so this activity falls right in line with parents' desires for media use. While the majority of parents are positive about their children's use of digital technology, many still have concerns about the content of the media such as the presence of violent or sexual content or the use of racial/ethnic or gender stereotypes (Rideout & Robb, 2020). Librarians are in a position to help in this area by staying aware of content options and providing quality recommendations.

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3.3: What We Learned

Songs and Movement

Our analysis found that the average number of words in a sung utterance (7.82) was higher than the average number of words (5.64) in a spoken utterance. An analysis of parts of speech used in utterances revealed that sung utterances used higher proportions of conjunctions and prepositions, indicating a higher utterance complexity because conjunctions and prepositions are used to add phrases and supplementary clauses. Singing gave children more opportunities to vocalize because 40.5% of the sung utterances were expressed by both the librarian and at least one child. Singing also provided more opportunities for movement. Children and librarians used movements, such as hand motions or dancing, along with 80% of the sung utterances but only 23.7% of the spoken utterances. Finally, the content and topics of sung versus spoken utterances were distinct from one another with sung utterances more likely to include repetitive words and action words (shake, jump, etc.).

Digital Technology

Detailed results from our analysis of the types of technology used during the storytimes we observed are not yet available, so we can only give general findings here. The most common digital technology used was a device to play songs or music. A few librarians used a projector attached to a computer to display song lyrics, behavior expectations, and/or announcements. One librarian used a CD player to play the audio version of a book while she held and turned the pages of the print version. None of the librarians used a handheld device to share an ebook. None of the librarians talked about the library's digital collection or educational digital resources for children.

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SECTION OVERVIEW

3.4: What You Can Do

3.4.1: Songs and Movement

3.4.2: Digital Technology

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3.4.1: Songs and Movement

You're likely already including songs and movement in your storytimes, and you've probably seen how much children enjoy them! You can use what we learned from both our study and research into best practices to reflect on the songs you use, to consider adding songs, and to consider how you can present songs to ensure their use is even more valuable to children's learning and school readiness.

Note: These selection and presentation strategies can also be used with action rhymes or chants.

Selection Strategies

As you think about choosing new songs to incorporate into storytime, try one or more of these research-based strategies to select songs most likely to promote school readiness.

Choose songs that are paired with movement. Researchers have found that children prefer songs played with movement over songs without (Walton, 2014).

Choose songs with action verbs. Children can learn these verbs through movement and repetition. Some suggestions:

- *Come Along and Sing with Me* (<https://kcls.org/content/come-along-and-sing-with-me/>)
- *Open, Shut Them* (<https://laurieberkner.com/song-lyrics/open-shut-them>)
- *Shake Your Sillies Out* (https://wiggles.fandom.com/wiki/Shake_Your_Sillies_Out)
- *This Is the Way* (<https://supersimple.com/song/this-is-the-way/>)

Choose a song that complements the theme of the session or the content of a chosen book. This helps promote both vocabulary and background knowledge for later reading. Many traditional English children's songs can be modified to include relevant vocabulary (Giles & Fresne, 2015). For example, *If You're Happy and You Know It* (<https://kidsongs.wordpress.com/2006/08/09/if-youre-happy-and-you-know-it/>) can be modified to relate to several common storytime themes or stories. For use with an animal theme, you might modify the song by using features of the animal: If you're a birdie and you know it, flap your wings, peck with your beak, shake your tail feathers, etc. For use with a story in which a character works through a strong emotion, you can change "happy" to another emotion such as sad, grumpy, frightened, or excited and use an appropriate accompanying movement.

Choose songs with concepts that are connected to school readiness such as counting, letters of the alphabet, shapes, size, colors, directional prepositions (e.g. over, under, in, out), days of the week, weather, seasons, and opposites. Some suggestions:

- *One, Two, Buckle My Shoe* (<https://kidsongs.com/lyrics/one-two-buckle-my-shoe.html>)
- *Two Little Blackbirds* (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gjv5Jwgsn7I>)
- *What Color Are You Wearing?* (<https://www.bussongs.com/songs/what-color-are-you-wearing>)

Choose songs representative of diverse cultures (Wiggins, 2007). These can be cultures within the community your library serves or from around the world. Check out:

- Short song videos in multiple languages from Colorado Libraries for Early Literacy's StoryBlocks project (<https://www.storyblocks.org/>)
- Lindsey Krabbenhoft's (2018) list of resources for Spanish-English bilingual storytimes (<https://jbrary.com/bilingual-storytime-resources/>), or
- Lisa Yannucci's collection of traditional songs from over 100 countries (<https://mamalisa.com>).

Invite caregivers to share favorite songs from their childhood. This can help all families feel welcome and introduce new vocabulary words.

Choose songs with rhyming words or alliteration (words that start with the same sound). A key building block of early literacy is phonological awareness, the ability to recognize that words are made up of sounds. Songs with repetitive sounds help children build this ability (Giles & Fresne, 2015; Riordan et al., 2018). Some suggestions:

- *Alliteration Song* [alliteration] (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=y-koivS_aho)
- *I'm a Little Teapot* [rhymes] (<https://www.kididdles.com/lyrics/i100.html>)
- *Twinkle, Twinkle Little Star* [rhymes] (<https://www.kididdles.com/lyrics/t023.html>)

Include songs that use fine motor skills (small muscle and finger movement) and songs that use gross motor skills (whole body or large muscle movement) in each session. This variety helps promote brain and physical development (Office of Head Start, 2015). Some suggestions:

- *Elevator Song* [gross motor] (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=afmFC-qwLCs>)
- *Head, Shoulders, Knees, and Toes* [gross motor] (<https://kidsongs.com/lyrics/head-shoulders-knees-and-toes.html>)
- *Hickory Dickory Dock* [fine motor] (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=uMNOZ7rC5hU&list=PLcw3Y8sV0xpvsWgtQ0nv1e9rxBqLJ_YSI&index=24)
- *Where is Thumbkin?* [fine motor] (<https://www.mamalisa.com/?t=es&p=1806>)

Virtual Variations: Song Selection and Copyright

Suggestion:

If you will be recording a storytime session, make sure there is no copyright restriction on any song lyrics, sound recording, or video you wish to share. Most of the songs suggested in these guidelines are traditional songs with lyrics in the public domain. However, the sound recording or video of such a song by a particular artist may be copyrighted by that artist. Therefore, it is advisable to learn the lyrics of the public domain song and perform it yourself, if you are recording your virtual storytime. Alternatively, if you do wish to use a song with copyright restrictions, you should contact the rights holder for permission. For more information about copyright considerations for storytime, consult the “Copyright Considerations” section of the ALSC’s and CLEL’s Virtual Storytime Services Resource Guide available at <https://www.ala.org/alsc/virtual-storytime-services-resource-guide>.

Support:

As one of their suggested best practices for virtual library programs, Nolet, Lockwood, and Gam (2021) recommend checking for copyright restrictions on any music shared during a recorded program.

Presentation Strategies

No matter what songs (or action rhymes or chants) you’ve chosen, the way you present each song can be thoughtfully chosen to promote early literacy and school readiness skills. Here are some research-based strategies to consider.

Change up the lyrics of familiar songs with synonyms to teach new words or with key vocabulary words from a story or your chosen theme (Wiggins, 2007). This can be a particularly helpful way to teach verbs.

Encourage continuous participation. If all children aren’t singing or moving along, pause and try these strategies:

- Slow down to teach the words: have the children repeat the lyrics after you one word at a time and then in short phrases before doing the whole song together.
- Teach the movements slowly and one at a time as well.
- As an alternative to asking children to perform an entire song, focus on a repeated word or phrase that they can sing along with you (Brown, 2009). Similarly, say or sing the lyrics but leave out obvious rhyming words, then ask the children to fill in the blanks (Brown, 2009).
- Ask caregivers to join you in encouraging the children by listing the school-readiness-related benefits of singing and movement:
 - Brain development
 - Language development
 - Muscle development
 - Muscle control
 - Joy
- Praise the ones who are singing and/or doing the movements (recognizing that some may only be able to do one or the other depending on cognitive and physical abilities/differences).
- Repetition, repetition, repetition! Try singing songs at least three times: the first time is an opportunity for children and caregivers to learn the words and motions; the second time is for everyone to practice; and the third time is for everyone to enjoy what they just learned. If everyone seems to be having a lot of fun, there’s nothing wrong with singing the song a fourth time too!

Promote vocabulary growth by using [direct vocabulary instruction](#) to teach a word or words from the song. Before singing, state the word, define the word with common words, and give an example of how the word is used in an everyday context. After singing, ask children to recall the definition of the word and encourage them to try using the word in a sentence of their own. To reinforce learning, repeat the word, definition, and example later in the storytime session.

As you teach the lyrics to the song, point out the words that rhyme or words that start with the same sound (alliterative words). As you sing the song, pause before repeated rhyming or alliterative words to let children fill in the words. After singing, ask children to share a word that rhymes with a word from the song or that starts with the same sound as a word in the song. These strategies can help promote phonological awareness (Giles & Fresne, 2015). Some suggestions:

- *The Name Game Song* (<https://thenamegame-generator.com/the-name-game-rules.html>)
- *Willoughby Wallaby Woo* (<https://genius.com/Raffi-willoughby-wallaby-woo-lyrics>)

Empower caregivers to participate by sharing the lyrics on paper or on a screen. This may be especially helpful for caregivers who are English language learners and can also help all caregivers learn the songs well enough to repeat them at home. However, be sensitive to the literacy levels of caregivers and do not assume that all can read the lyrics.

Guide children and caregivers to create a steady, calming beat to lullabies and nursery rhymes by patting their knees or thighs rhythmically or by swaying or rocking rhythmically while standing. Repetitive, calm movements help children practice listening, concentration, and muscle control (Giles & Fresne, 2015).

Online Resources:

- *Children's Songs with Lyrics* – organized by themes and searchable, some with music files, curated by educator Francis Morgan - <https://www.kididdles.com/>
- *Flipcharts of Rhymes* – list of songs curated by early literacy expert Saroj Ghoting with lyrics in downloadable files - <http://www.earlylit.net/storytime-resources>
- *Kids Songs* – lyrics searchable by topic or title - <https://kidsongs.wordpress.com/>
- *Mama Lisa's World: International Music and Culture* - Lisa Yannucci's collection of lyrics for traditional songs from over 100 countries, organized by country, language, or type of song, some with video or music files - (<https://mamalisa.com>).
- *YouTube Playlists* – videos of songs performed by librarians Lindsey Krabbenhoft and Dana Horrocks, organized by broad categories - <https://jbrary.com/youtube-playlists/>

3.4.1: [Songs and Movement](#) is shared under a [not declared](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

3.4.2: Digital Technology

While many types of digital technology are available, we will focus this section on four types: music players, visual or video devices, ebooks, and educational digital media. As you read about selection and presentation strategies, keep in mind two important aspects of each type of digital technology: 1.) how you can use it to enhance your storytimes and 2.) how you can talk to caregivers about how to use the technology and related library resources to support children's learning and development. We acknowledge that access to digital technology may be outside of your control for many reasons. We also acknowledge that digital technology changes rapidly in its availability or popularity, so these guidelines will focus more on general principles for choosing and using technology than on specific device or app recommendations.

Music Player Selection and Presentation Strategies

Preparation is key to successfully using a music player during storytime. Set up the player in the area beforehand, giving yourself time to test its use. Choose a spot that you will be able to physically access easily and quickly to allow for smooth transitions between using the player and conducting other activities. With the device playing, walk around the area where the audience will be to test that the volume is clear but not overwhelmingly loud. Always have a back-up selection of songs, rhymes, or chants that you can perform without accompaniment in case the technology fails at the spur of the moment.

If possible, choose a music player that plays songs in a medium to which your library provides access so that you can talk about the library's music resources with caregivers. If the songs are available in more than one medium, such as on a borrowable CD and also through one of the library's lending databases, all the better! Because some of your patrons may not have Internet access at home, highlighting both off- and online music resources is good practice for inclusivity.

Visual or Video Device Selection and Presentation Strategies

The strategies for choosing and using a device that presents visuals and/or videos follow similar principles to choosing and using a music player. Preparation is key. Set up the device in the area beforehand, giving yourself time to test its use. Choose a spot that you will be able to physically access easily and quickly to allow for smooth transitions between using the device and conducting other activities. Alternatively, if the device has a remote, practice using it in the place you will be for the storytime to make sure the connection to the remote is secure. With the device playing, walk around the area where the audience will be to test that the volume is clear but not overwhelmingly loud and that the screen can be seen reasonably well from all angles. If you are using the device to play a video, prepare an alternative activity to do in case the technology fails at the spur of the moment for whatever reason (as technology can be wont to do). If you are using the device to display information, create a few printed versions for your own reference and to have on hand in case a caregiver asks for a copy.

Useful information to consider displaying:

- *A general agenda for the storytime*, listing the activities you intend to do in order. Use both words and an image for each activity, creating a visual agenda that can be especially helpful to children with cognitive differences (Bohanon, 2020).
- *Lyrics for songs, rhymes, or chants* as you use them. This can be especially helpful for storytime attendees who are unfamiliar with them or who are English language learners (ELL).
- *A list with the authors, illustrators, and titles of the books* you've selected for the session.
- *Advertisements for upcoming library programs* for children and families. This can be a good display to have up as attendees enter and/or leave the storytime area.
- *Images or video clips with content related to the storytime topic* can enhance children's understanding and enjoyment. For example, choose photographs or video clips from an informational article, documentary, or nature show about an animal alongside a picturebook starring the animal.

As you choose a video to play, consider how you can highlight the library's video resources such as DVDs or a streaming service, if available. Because some of your patrons may not have Internet access at home, highlighting both offline and online resources is good practice for inclusivity. You can also plan to say a sentence or two to explain to caregivers why you chose this video, such as what makes it age-appropriate, what school readiness skill it can help children to practice, and/or how it connects to and expands on the theme of the storytime or the main idea of a shared book.

Ebook Selection Strategies

As you think about choosing and presenting ebooks, it may be helpful to know some benefits of sharing ebooks.

- An overall benefit of sharing ebooks is that they can increase children's enjoyment and engagement with reading (Hoffman & Paciga, 2013). In a survey we conducted as part of this storytime study, we found that children's enjoyment was one of the most frequently chosen reasons that motivated caregivers to take their child or children to storytime (see [4.4.1 Caregiver Goal - Enjoyment](#) for more details).
- Another benefit is modeling reading practices so that children can begin to understand how people in our modern culture use digital devices to read for entertainment and information gathering (Hoffman & Paciga, 2013).
- Strouse, Newland, and Mourlam (2019) found that while parents did not see ebooks as a way to have positive bonding and learning experiences with children, children did see this use for ebooks; so the caregivers in your storytime may benefit from seeing children's enthusiasm for ebooks as you model how to use them for shared reading.

Selecting ebooks to include in your storytime takes just as much careful planning as selecting print books. All of the best practices for selecting books based on their content, design, and illustrations presented in [Path 2: Considerations for Selecting Books](#) also apply to selecting ebooks, so you can consider them first when selecting high-quality ebooks to share or recommend (Hoffman & Paciga, 2013; Neuman, Wong, & Kaefer, 2017). In addition, evaluating ebooks involves considering the quality of features specific to the digital format. Ebooks for young children can vary widely in the types of features they include and in the quality of these features (Hoffman & Paciga, 2013; Yokota & Teale, 2017). Different types of features can provide an array of benefits to children's learning of school readiness skills. This section gives an overview of features to look for and how they can benefit children.

One very common feature of ebooks is the option to have the text read aloud by a narrator, sometimes called the "read to me" option or read-aloud feature. Even though this feature commonly appears, it is not guaranteed to be of high quality because some ebooks have narration that is too loud or that is not timed correctly with the words on the screen (Reich, Yau, & Warschauer, 2016; Yokota & Teale, 2014). This can be true even of ebooks with high ratings on review websites (Yokota & Teale, 2014), so be sure to play through and carefully listen to the entire ebook before choosing it for storytime use. You might think that you don't have to evaluate the read-aloud feature if you're going to mute it and read the text aloud yourself during the storytime, but consider that caregivers attending storytime may perceive your use of the ebook as an endorsement and want to borrow or purchase the ebook themselves for their child to read independently, using the read-aloud feature. While you can emphasize to caregivers that children benefit from more enjoyment and learning when an adult reads the ebook aloud, some may still prefer to use the electronic narration, so a consideration of the narration quality should be part of your evaluation.

A feature that often accompanies the read-aloud feature is a text highlighting feature that changes the font or background color of the text as the text is read aloud. Again, this may be a feature that you won't use in your storytime presentation but that may be helpful for recommending ebooks for children to use independently at home. Studies have found that ebooks with this and other features that focus attention on story content and vocabulary can support children's reading comprehension (Neuman et al., 2017; O'Toole and Kannass, 2018).

Another feature that consistently promotes learning, especially in the areas of oral language and vocabulary, is a hotspot that displays and pronounces a word. A hotspot is a place on the screen that when touched produces a visual and/or audio effect (Reich et al., 2016). For example, in the tablet version of *Polar Bear Horizon*, when a reader touches the hotspot on an object in the illustration, the application displays the word of the object on top of the object and the narrator reads the word aloud (Zhou & Yadav, 2017). In their study of young children's vocabulary learning from ebooks and print books, Zhou and Yadav (2017) found that children who independently read an ebook with such hotspots had significantly higher vocabulary learning than children who were read aloud a print version of the book by an adult. Many caregivers may be interested in how children can learn from ebooks independently, so taking some time during storytimes to explain the benefits of choosing a book with hotspots that display and pronounce words can help you aid caregivers' selection of books.

This vocabulary-boosting hotspot is part of a type of feature that might be called a congruent or integral feature, one that "... will complement and extend the plot and/or [display] information to help readers better understand story elements and concepts presented" (Hoffman & Paciga, 2013, p. 282). In other words, hotspots that support the story elements or main ideas of the book support children's learning. Some helpful congruent features are music that matches the mood of the character or setting, letters that make the letter sound when tapped, animation or motion that dramatize action in the scene; and sound effects that correspond

to story actions or objects (Reich et al., 2016; Sung & Chen, 2019; Yokota and Teale, 2014). Congruent features have not only been found to improve a child's reading comprehension and vocabulary when the child interacts with an ebook independently (Neuman, Wong, & Kaefer, 2017; Sung & Chen, 2019; Zipke, 2017) but have also been found to aid adult-child discussions of the text's central ideas during shared ebook reading (Hoffman & Paciga, 2013). In other words, congruent features are beneficial whether a child is reading an ebook independently or with a caregiver.

Other features to look for in choosing ebooks are those that promote math learning. Ebooks that provide children practice with early numeracy, cardinality, addition, and symbolic representation of numbers can result in significant learning. In addition to this, when reading math ebooks, children have been found to exhibit high levels of motivation, engagement, and attention (Uscianowski et al., 2018).

Ebook Presentation Strategies

Even if your library's lack of a specific technology or the large size of your storytime audience prevents you from reading aloud an ebook, you can talk to caregivers during storytime to explain how and why to use ebooks, encouraging them to check out your library's digital collection. For example, when you find an ebook worth recommending, obtain a copy of the print version to read aloud during storytime. After the reading, explain to caregivers that the ebook version is available to check out and describe one or two features it has that make it a good pick for increasing children's learning.

Interactions

Just as with sharing print books, adult-child interactions when reading ebooks are essential to promote school readiness in children. Studies show over and over again that preschool-aged children reap numerous learning benefits from shared reading no matter the medium of the book (Reich et al., 2016; Reich et al., 2019; Sung & Chen, 2019). Read through [Path 1: Strategies for Effective Librarian-Child Interactions](#) for detailed explanations of research-based interaction strategies. While you may have to talk a little about how the ebook device works, be careful not to let device-focused talk dominate (Hoffman & Paciga, 2013). It is helpful to plan out the questions and discussion you will have around the content of the ebook, focusing on the story elements or main ideas as well as the early literacy or school readiness skill you'd like to promote.

Asides

To make your use of ebooks particularly impactful, include asides in which you explain to caregivers that you are modeling how to interact with the ebook in ways that promote the child's school readiness. Caregivers may benefit from direct explanations and examples of school-readiness-promoting interactions because some studies of parent/child pairs show that parents naturally talk more about the mechanics of the device during ebook reading than about story or print elements (Reich et al., 2016). Additionally, Strouse and colleagues' (2019) survey of parents found that parents are less likely to interact with children as they use ebooks than as they read print books. Therefore, caregivers can benefit from discussions of how and why to read ebooks along with children and use interaction strategies that enhance the child's experience and learning. For more encouragement about how to use asides to improve your storytime, read the [4.4.4 Spotlight on Asides](#).

Caregivers are likely open to guidance in selecting ebooks. For example, one survey of 43 U.S. parents found that while 100% read print books to their children and 93% allowed their children to use a digital device such as a tablet or smartphone at least once every week, only 53% answered that their children read or listened to stories with a digital device at least once a week (Strouse et al., 2019). This indicates that caregivers are aware of the benefits of print books and have access to digital devices and thus may be open to sharing ebooks with children once they understand their educational benefits and have some ideas for how to choose high-quality ebooks.

Educational Digital Media Selection and Presentation Strategies

Familiarity with how to use and learn from digital media has become part of school readiness because an increasing number of elementary schools use digital media for everyday instruction and for assessment (Vittrup et al., 2016). Consider how you might incorporate interactions with digital media into your storytime activities by showing and talking about the media or giving children a chance to interact with the media at the end of or after the storytime session.

You can use what you know about how children learn to evaluate educational digital media. Research shows that children learn best when they are actively engaged in a task and interacting socially with an adult or peer (Hirsh-Pasek et al., 2015). Thus, the best

educational digital media will encourage engagement and interaction. Educational applications (apps) or websites accessed on a smartphone or tablet have the potential to be engaging because the child can interact with the content by touching the screen (Terrell & Watson, 2018). However, experts caution that young children will get the most enjoyment and learning from such apps or websites when a caregiver guides them through its use and talks with them about the learning content (Reich et al., 2016; Terrell & Watson, 2018). Additionally, many apps and websites include games, music, or sound effects irrelevant to the main content that can be distracting to children (Reich et al., 2016). So as you evaluate these interactive elements, look and listen for those that clearly connect to the content or skill to be learned. Share your knowledge of the importance of interactivity to learning with parents and caregivers as you demonstrate educational apps. These apps may best be shared at the end or after a storytime because it takes time for each child to interact with you and a tablet or other device.

For examples of educational digital media worth recommending, check out the winners of Association for Library Service to Children's Excellence in Early Learning Digital Media Award found at <https://alsc-awards-shelf.org/directory/results?booklist=19>.

Ebook and Digital Media Online Resources

These recommended websites for finding high-quality ebooks and digital media for improving school readiness are adapted from the recommendations of Hoffman and Paciga (2013) and Guernsey and Levine (2016). The websites were last checked for recent content by one of the authors of these guidelines in August of 2021.

- <https://commonsensemedia.org/> - reviews written by caregivers, experts, and children that are searchable by best of lists and audience age; though frequently recommended by scholars, the free version of this resource offers limited access
- <https://digital-storytime.com> – reviews written by educators and caregivers that are searchable by audience age and keyword
- <https://www.parentschoice.org/product-category/mobile-apps/> - reviews written by educators and caregivers that are searchable by best of lists and audience age
- <https://www.parentschoice.org/product-category/websites/> - reviews written by educators, experts, and caregivers that are searchable by best of lists and audience age
- <https://www.teacherswithapps.com/> - reviews written by educators and experts that are searchable by audience age, subject/topic, and keyword

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

Path 4: Caregiver Goals for Storytimes

4.1: What We Looked At

4.2: Why It Matters

4.3: What We Learned

4.4: What You Can Do

4.4.1: Caregiver Goal- Enjoyment

4.4.2: Caregiver Goal- Children Socializing

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4.4.4: Spotlight on Asides

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4.1: What We Looked At

We distributed surveys to the caregivers who attended the 68 storytime sessions we observed at 35 libraries. A total of 346 caregivers responded to the 13 survey questions. Our primary research question was, “Why do caregivers choose for the children in their care to attend storytimes?”

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4.2: Why It Matters

While the general public has high regard for storytimes, these programs are understudied in the library science field (Dowd, 1997; Young, Sarroub, & Babchuk, 2019). More information about caregivers' perceptions and priorities related to storytime can help you tailor your storytimes to better serve your community members (Rankin & Brock, 2015). Additionally, when caregivers support children's literacy, children make better progress in learning (Rankin & Brock, 2015).

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4.3: What We Learned

Over 75% of the survey respondents chose “My child enjoys hearing stories and participating in storytime activities” as a main reason for attending storytime. The second most popular reason caregivers chose for attending storytime was the opportunity for children to meet and interact with other children. Many also chose “My child learns important skills and concepts” and “Storytime helps prepare my child for school” as their top reasons for attending storytime. We found that caregivers who had been attending storytimes for more than one year were more likely to choose school readiness as a reason to attend, perhaps indicating that they learned the importance of this goal from attending storytime.

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SECTION OVERVIEW

4.4: What You Can Do

These sections explain some ideas for improving your storytimes based on caregivers' desired goals found through our surveys.

4.4.1: Caregiver Goal- Enjoyment

4.4.2: Caregiver Goal- Children Socializing

4.4.3: Caregiver Goal- School Readiness

4.4.4: Spotlight on Asides

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4.4.1: Caregiver Goal- Enjoyment

Storytimes are fun! But they aren't *just* fun. Enjoying activities during storytime can help prepare children to enjoy school. For example, participation in enjoyable activities can contribute to children's intrinsic (self-driven) motivation and self-efficacy (belief in one's ability to succeed at tasks) (Koops & Kuebel, 2018).

There are generally three things research shows you can look for to see if children are enjoying an activity (Koops & Kuebel, 2018); keep in mind not all children, especially those 3- years-old or younger and children with disabilities or developmental delays, express enjoyment in these ways.

1. Affective [emotional] behavior: Are they showing positive emotions by smiling or laughing?
2. Continuation responses: Do they try or ask to repeat an activity?
3. Participation: Are they participating by listening, vocalizing, or moving in ways appropriate to the activity?

Ask yourself these questions as you go through storytime activities old and new, and plan to repeat the activities that bring the most enjoyment to the most children. As an added bonus, repetition helps children learn!

Enjoyment is often linked to engagement. Studies have shown that children are the most actively engaged during shared reading when they sit close to the reader (Paciga et al., 2015) and when their caregiver sits close to them (Campana, Kociubuk, & Mills, 2020). If your caregiver attendees are used to sitting in the back or in an outer ring around the inner circle of you and the children, try changing things up by verbally encouraging caregivers to sit with and participate along with children by sitting in a cluster arrangement (see figure 4.4.1.1). Take away most of the chairs but leave some for caregivers with accessibility needs. Seating can be a small change that makes an important difference in children's enjoyment and learning!

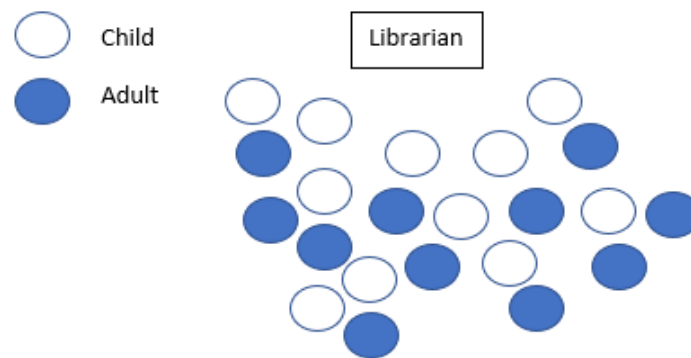


Figure 4.4.1.1: Cluster Seating Arrangement Example. (Copyright; author via source)

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4.4.2: Caregiver Goal- Children Socializing

Socializing is another goal of caregivers that you can integrate into existing storytime goals because social play contributes to both early literacy and school readiness skills. Play is one of the five practices for building early literacy included in the second edition of the *Every Child Ready to Read* (ECRR) initiative (Association for Library Services to Children & Public Library Association, 2011), so many ECRR-trained librarians meaningfully include play in storytime sessions (Celano, Knapczyk, & Neuman, 2018). Both you, as the storytime provider, and the caregivers have an integral role in facilitating children's play because your conversations with children during play can increase their engagement and language learning (Celano et al., 2018; Terrell & Watson, 2018). Interactive play has also been found to improve children's social and emotional learning (McClelland et al., 2017).

Here are some ideas for play activities you might try before, during, and/or after a storytime.

- **During and After:** To facilitate **dramatic play**, set out toys (such as blocks, puppets, stuffed animals) or props (hats, clothing, household items) that relate to the theme of the storytime. During storytime, tell the caregivers about the toys and how “pretend play” can help children build the early literacy skill of vocabulary as they try out new words while acting out all or parts of the stories and songs they heard (Terrell & Watson, 2018). For example, after William H. Teale (1999) guided preschool-age children in acting out a story with grocery-bag vests, a cardboard mask, and a cape, the children enjoyed repeatedly reenacting the story on their own. Diversity note: when providing materials that represent people (puppets, action figures, etc.), include a range of skin colors, facial features, gender expressions, and abilities. Dramatic play also provides opportunities to explore concepts, images, and experiences from a variety of cultures.
- **During and After:** Design a **play area with a literacy-related theme**, imitating a place from the real world in which reading and/or writing are needed to get tasks done. In addition to an opportunity for social play, literacy-themed play areas can also help promote a child's “disposition to literacy” or “child's fundamental realization that reading and writing are meaningful, purposeful, goal-directed activities that people use to help them get things done in their lives” (Teale, 1999). During storytime, read stories set in the area and model how children can play together with items that will be in the area. Here are some suggestions for literacy-themed play areas and their word-rich contents (Teale, 1999; Terrell and Watson, 2018):
 - Office: calendars, schedules, checklists, inspirational posters, writing materials
 - Post office: stamps, envelopes, boxes with labels, writing materials
 - Restaurant: open/closed sign, menus [with images of culturally diverse food], order pads for wait staff, receipts, credit cards
 - Doctor's office: eye chart, simple diagram with labeled body parts
 - Grocery store: shopping lists, sales signs, product labels, coupons, receipts, printed circulars [all with culturally diverse products]
- **During and After:** Diamant-Cohen, Prendergast, Estrovitz, Banks, and van der Veen's (2012) simple directions for a “**literacy café**” could be adapted to create various scenarios: “Create a literacy café! With a simple set of dishes, a table, and some graphics taped down (burner, grill, etc.), you will soon see dramatic play blossom. Add in a menu of play for caregivers (with suggestions for how to interact at various ages and with a few jokes for good measure), and you'll have a bustle of play right next to a collection of books selected for the experience. Soon you'll see a child consult a 'cookbook' in dramatic play, use a book as a serving platter, and even ask a parent to choose from a board book menu of fruit shapes” (p. 10).
- **During:** Lead children in an activity that requires them to **work together toward a common goal**. Some examples:
 - Take turns using large blocks to build a given structure such as a tall tower.
 - Stand together in a circle and use their hands to pass around and keep balloons or lightweight balls up in the air for as long as they can.
 - Take turns placing pieces to complete a jigsaw puzzle.
 - Create a piece of art together. An example: lay out a large piece of butcher paper, have an adult spread clear-drying glue on it, and then give children cut pieces of multi-colored tissue paper to sprinkle over the paper, asking children to work together and share paper to spread out the colors.
- **During:** Direct children in a game of **Follow the Leader** and then call on volunteer children to lead. Younger children could choose a body part for everyone to point at or to wiggle while older children could choose an animal or emotion for everyone to act out.

- **During or After:** Ask children to bring a toy from home for **Show and tell**. Pair up each child and their caregiver with another child and caregiver and have each child show and talk about their toy. (For younger or non-verbal children, the caregivers can talk and encourage physical or tonal interactions or responses.) You might ask a pair of attendees you know well to volunteer by modeling what a Show and Tell conversation might look like at the beginning of this activity.
- **Before and/or After:** Place **musical instruments** in a play area for children to use independently. Young children often spontaneously play together to make music, trying to imitate one another or to coordinate sounds, especially with larger instruments such as a xylophone or bongo drum (Young, 2008).
- **Before and/or After:** Provide **building blocks for free play**. As your budget allows, provide blocks of varying sizes, shapes, colors, textures, and materials for children with varying interests and abilities to manipulate. Children can practice social skills while sharing blocks, building something together, or playing with their creations. Building with blocks may also help children develop other school readiness skills such as problem solving, curiosity, creativity, and spatial and procedural skills (Prendergast, 2012).

Creating time and space for social play can also be a way to increase the inclusiveness of your storytime program. Diamant-Cohen, Prendergast, Estrovitz, Banks, and van der Veen (2012) offer this advice for creating playtimes that welcome children with developmental, linguistic, cognitive, and/or physical differences and facilitate their literacy and social development.

- Make sure the play area is physically accessible and has supportive seating such as cube chairs or foam blocks that can assist children in playing on the floor and/or at tables.
- Provide toys and learning materials that appeal to multiple senses as well as the same toy in various formats. Diamant-Cohen and colleagues (2012) provide an example with toy trains: “wooden trains, Lego trains, and remote-control trains will accommodate children with a wide range of physical and intellectual abilities” (p. 8).
- Encourage the use of all kinds of communication, including sign language, communication boards, or electronic devices, by talking with children and caregivers about these various forms that “talking” can take.
- Allow time for both adult-guided and unstructured play. Adult-guided play occurs when the adult suggest to the child or children what to do as they play. In unstructured play, the child chooses what to do. An example of adult-guided play is when you lead children to take turns putting felt pieces on a board in order to re-tell a story you read aloud previously. An example of unstructured play would be to leave out the board and pieces for children to play with on their own after the formal storytime ends. The same can be done with props or puppets.

If you’d like to learn more about creating play areas that promote school readiness skills in children, Saroj Ghoting provides many informational sources with examples in the Environments section of her website: <http://www.earlylit.net/environments>.

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4.4.3: Caregiver Goal- School Readiness

Our study of storytime attendees indicates that caregivers value school readiness as a goal of storytimes. School readiness includes a variety of skills, behaviors, and knowledge that children may develop so that they can enter school ready to be successful. One way to think about school readiness comes from the [Head Start Early Learning Outcomes Framework](#) [external link] which details five domains of school readiness: 1.) approaches to learning; 2.) cognition; 3.) language and literacy; 4.) perceptual, motor, and physical development; and 5.) social and emotional development (Office of Head Start, 2015). Although this framework was designed for use in early education classrooms, it is readily applicable to the informal learning environment of storytimes because many of the behaviors that indicate progress in each domain can be encouraged during storytime activities, especially shared book reading. Below you'll find explanations of each domain along with related strategies you can implement in storytime sessions throughout the year.

Approaches to Learning

Explanation	how children learn
Some Included Skills	creativity; initiative; curiosity; working memory; emotional, behavioral, and cognitive self-regulation; following routines
Suggested Strategy: Question an Informational Text	Choose an informational text about an animal with many vivid illustrations and show one of the illustrations to the children. Ask children to share one thing they already know about the animal. Then ask one thing they want to know. (In case of low participation, prepare to guide the activity with pre-chosen questions such as "What does it eat?" or "Where does it live?") Take each question one by one and talk aloud as you use the table of contents, indexes, and/or glossary to search for answers. If the answer can't be found in the chosen text, discuss other ways children might find information. (For more ideas on choosing and using informational texts, read the Spotlight On Informational Texts .)
Suggested Strategy: Story Action	The goal of this strategy is to build children's working memory. Before reading a story with a repeated phrase, show children an action they can do whenever they hear you read that phrase and give a hand signal (such as holding your hand out to them, palm up). Ideally, the action should correspond to the phrase. For example, if the phrase included the word "pout," the action might include children making a pouty face. As you read, pause and give the hand signal before saying the phrase. If no children respond, repeat the phrase and signal again. If necessary, repeat the instructions. The goal is to scaffold all children so that they remember and do the action on their own by the end of the story.
Suggested Strategy: Directed Transitions	To give children practice in understanding and following routines, give directions out loud and explain expectations as you transition from one storytime activity to another. Using a visual aid such as a photo or illustration of a child doing the expected behavior is also helpful. Display these aids on a wall or screen to keep your hands free.
Related Ideas in This Guide	Path 1: Behavior Management Path 2: Spotlight on Informational Texts Path 5: Improve Support for Historically Underserved Groups - Families of Children with Differing Abilities or Cognitive Differences

Cognition

Explanation	thinking that helps children understand and organize their world
Some Included Skills	exploration; planning; problem-solving; imitation; counting; addition and subtraction; pattern identification; understanding shapes; scientific reasoning
Suggested Problem-Solving Picturebook	Strategy: Share a picturebook in which the characters work together and make several attempts to solve a problem. During the reading, pause to ask the children whether they think the proposed solution will work and why or why not. After reading, ask the children why the solution worked and what other solutions may have worked. (This strategy pairs well with the Strive for 5 strategy from Path 1)
Suggested Counting Songs with Props	Strategy: Choose some favorites from the many available counting songs for preschoolers and create props or visual aids to share as the children sing. The combination of sight and sound helps reinforce this important cognitive skill. A research-proven strategy for teaching cardinality is to label the number of items in a set and then count the items (Mix et al., 2012).
Suggested Pattern Activities	Strategy: Lead children in an activity in which you ask them to extend a simple pattern (“What comes next?”) or identify the missing element in a given pattern (“What should go here?”). You can do this with toys such as blocks or stuffed animals, with movements to a song or chant, with a flannel board activity, or with sounds you ask them to create on musical instruments.
Related Ideas in This Guide	Path 1: Instructional Support Domain - Concept Development Path 2: School Readiness Focus: Approaches to Learning and Cognition

Language and Literacy

Explanation	language: abilities in listening to language, understanding language, and using language literacy: knowledge and skills related to reading and writing
Some Included Skills	communicating needs; communicating to gain information; vocabulary; following social and conversational rules; self-expression; imitating words and phrases; story comprehension; phonological awareness; print and alphabet knowledge
Suggested Strategy: Open-Ended Prompts	Open-ended prompts have more than one correct answer and require more than one word to answer completely, giving children opportunities to use new vocabulary and complex sentence structures (Hindman et al., 2019). After reading a story, use open-ended prompts to help children recall details and make connections to themselves. Here are some example prompts to adapt and try out: • Which character did you like best and why? • What is one thing the character(s) did in the story? • Have you ever ____? (insert potentially common activity from the story) • How did the character(s) feel and why? • What was your favorite part? • Did anything remind you of another story or show? Remember to wait at least 5 seconds after asking open-ended prompts to let those young minds think! For more on open-ended prompts, see Path 1: Instructional Support Domain – Language Modeling.
Suggested Strategy: Print Referencing	Studies have shown that children rarely look at print or initiate conversations about print on their own during shared reading (Evans & Saint-Aubin, 2011). Yet, knowledge of print is a foundational early literacy skill. Encourage children to look at print by using print referencing: pointing to a word on the page as you talk about it. You can do this with vocabulary words you’ve chosen to teach or simply with words that stand out because of their style, talking to children about what that style tells you as a reader. For example, as you read an informational text, you might point to the heading of the page and tell children that you know this is the heading because the words are bigger and/or in another color than other words on the page. For another example, as you read a picturebook, you might point to words written in large letters on the page and explain that the large letters show you, the reader, that the character is shouting.
Suggested Strategy: Category Monster	Construct a “monster” out of a cardboard box by cutting a wide hole for its mouth and using construction paper or what have you to give it eyes, ears, horns, polka dots, spikes, etc. Tell the children this is a Category Monster because it only wants to eat things in a certain category or that have a particular characteristic or trait. It also eats paper clips. Examples of categories might be things that are red, an animal with four legs, or things that start with the letter D. Then pass out objects (or pictures of objects) to each child. Have each child come forward and decide if their object fits the category the monster wants to eat. If it fits, they “feed” it to the monster by putting it through the mouth hole. If it doesn’t fit, they give you the object and you give them a paper clip to “feed” to the monster, so that every child has an opportunity to feed the monster. For large groups, instead of giving children the objects, display the objects or pictures and tell children that if they think you should feed it to the monster, they can hold up a hand, make a chomping motion, and/or make chomping noises with their mouths.
Related Ideas in This Guide	Path 1: Instructional Support Domain – Language Modeling Path 2: Equity, Diversity, and Inclusion in Book Selection Path 2: School Readiness Focus: Language and Literacy

Perceptual, Motor, and Physical Development

Explanation	perceptual: using the five senses to acquire and understand information about the world motor: using the whole body or large muscles for gross motor movement and using small muscles, especially in the hands, for fine motor movement physical: knowledge and use of positive health, safety, and nutrition behaviors
Some Included Skills	using perceptual information to interact with objects and people; muscle control; coordination; following personal hygiene routines; identifying healthy and unhealthy foods; following personal safety rules
Suggested Strategy: Fine Motor Crafts	Many storytimes already include a craft time as an ending or extension activity because working with crafting tools like crayons and brushes gives children fun practice with the fine motor movements they'll later use to write with a pen or use a computer mouse. Many websites offer ideas for simple preschool crafts, or you can lay out supplies and let children's imaginations be their guide. Invest in construction paper, crayons, watercolor paints and brushes, glue sticks, safety scissors, and/or other craft supplies as your community's needs and program budgets allow. Library staff or volunteers may be interested in helping you plan and organize these craft times. Encourage caregivers to talk with children as they create to also strengthen language skills. (Read more about Language Modeling in Path 1.)
Suggested Strategy: Senses Observation	Bring in an object or set of objects for the children to pass around and observe with their senses. The object could be an everyday item such as a cup or leaf or rarer item such as a sports trophy or seashell. Using a visual aid - such as a poster with drawings of eyes, ears, a nose, and hands – ask children what they observe about the object by seeing, listening to, smelling, and touching it. As an adaptation, especially for large groups, you could pre-determine a list of descriptive words, some that fit the object and some that don't, and then recite each word asking the children to point to a body part (eyes, ears, nose, or hand) to show which sense the word relates to and then raise a hand if they think the word fits today's object. Perceptual development and language learning all in one!
Suggested Strategy: Silly Dance Circle	Invite children and their caregivers to stand in a circle. Together sing and act out two verses of the Hokey Pokey. Then explain that the Hokey Pokey is a silly dance someone made up and today everyone will have a chance to make up their own silly dance. Demonstrate a dance move of your creation and invite the children and caregivers to do it along with you. Since children's creations may closely resemble your model, try to include both arm and leg movements in your creation. Then call on child volunteers to share their own silly dance moves for you and the rest to do along with them. Encourage them to pick a silly name for their silly dance. (For an overview of the scientific support for the connection between dancing and learning, read Judith Hanna's (2016) blog post, "What Educators and Parents Should Know About Neuroplasticity, Learning and Dance.")
Related Ideas in This Guide	Path 2: School Readiness Focus: Perceptual, Motor, and Physical Development and Social and Emotional Development Path 3: Songs and Movement

Social and Emotional Development

Explanation	social: ability to create and maintain relationships with other children and adults emotional: ability to express, identify, and manage own emotions and to give appropriate responses to others' expressed emotions
Some Included Skills	seeking help from familiar adults; cooperative play; basic conflict resolution; labeling own and others' emotions; using expressions of care and concern; coping strategies
Suggested Strategy: Emotion Cube	Create an emotion cube: do an internet search to find pictures of faces that represent six common feelings - embarrassed, angry, proud, happy, sad, and nervous; print out the pictures; paste the pictures on the six sides of a square box (Harper, 2016). After reading a story in which characters experience all or most of those emotions, have a child roll the emotion cube like a die. Then ask which character had that emotion and what story event caused the emotion or what the character did because of the emotion. Some adaptations: ask the child to mimic the cube's facial expression; ask the child to talk about what makes them feel the emotion or what they do when they feel it; lead all children in singing a verse of "If You're Happy and You Know It" modified to fit the emotion on the cube with an appropriate action.
Suggested Strategy: Yoga Breaks	Among sharing stories, songs, and energetic activities, help children learn the calming strategy of practicing easy yoga poses. Practicing yoga can give children a coping strategy they can use while learning how to regulate their emotions (McClelland et al., 2017). Picturebooks about yoga for kids may be available from your library's collection. You can find free videos on YouTube such as those from Cosmic Kids Yoga.
Suggested Strategy: Conflict Resolution Discussion	Studies indicate that children more easily transfer problem-solving ideas from picturebooks with realistic contexts and characters rather than those with fantastical contexts and non-human characters (Strouse et al., 2018). Share a book with realistic characters facing a simple social conflict. In a discussion using open-ended questions, ask children to describe the problem. Then ask children to describe how the characters solved the problem. As an extension, ask children what other ways the characters could have tried to resolve the conflict.
Related Ideas in This Guide	Path 2: School Readiness Focus: Perceptual, Motor, and Physical Development and Social and Emotional Development Path 4: Caregiver Goal - Children Socializing

Other useful resources for understanding school readiness and for more teaching and modeling strategies to implement in your storytime practices include:

- Public Library of Youngstown and Mahoning County's Implementation Guides - <https://www.libraryvisit.org/kids/resources-for-librarians/> - detailed lists of storytime activities for supporting school readiness, broken down by the five early learning domains and by ages
- Saroj Ghoting's Early Literacy Planning Tool based on Every Child Ready to Read (ECRR) (<https://static1.squarespace.com/static/531bd3f2e4b0a09d95833bfc/t/5b62929b1ae6cf5b12556cc2/1533186717601/6ELPT71518nool.pdf>) - for each of ECRR's six literacy components (phonological awareness, print awareness, print motivation, background knowledge, letter knowledge, and vocabulary) this guide provides storytime practices that a librarian may do with corresponding behaviors children may demonstrate, organized by age level
- Reimagining School Readiness Toolkit - <https://bayareadiscoverymuseum.org/resources/educator-resources/library-toolkit> - This toolkit provides a varied set of resources for program improvement strategies connected to findings from a review of research in cognitive and developmental psychology, developed specifically for library staff by the Bay Area Discovery Museum and California State Library's Early Learning with Families initiative.
- The CDC's Developmental Milestones (<https://www.cdc.gov/ncbddd/actearly/milestones/index.html>) - lists of how children might act, learn, move, play, and speak at different ages from 2 months to 5 years, with many example videos and pictures

Understanding school readiness indicators and milestones can help you choose activities that are within a child's zone of proximal development, or ZPD. ZPD is used to describe a range of activities that lie in between what a child can accomplish independently and what a child can do with scaffolding and support from an adult or more advanced peer (Terrell & Watson, 2018; Vygotsky,

1986). Children learn best when they engage in activities within their ZPD (Terrell & Watson, 2018; Vygotsky, 1986). Using the resources above, observe what children already know and do and talk to their attending caregivers about their knowledge and abilities. Then, plan activities that can help children both show off their current level and try something at the next level. As children's ZPDs will vary, be careful to plan a range of activities in each session so that every child has the opportunity to be successful.

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4.4.4: Spotlight on Asides

The Strategy:

Would you like to ...

... inspire children's learning that continues outside of storytime?

... empower caregivers to develop new knowledge and skills?

... enhance your leadership skills?

If you answer yes to any of the above, try this: **use an aside to explain to caregivers how and why what you're doing helps children build school readiness** (Ghoting & Martin-Diaz, 2006).

The Reasoning:

Our survey results indicate that many caregivers attend storytime in order to increase their child's school readiness. Many early childhood studies have shown that the most important factor in preparing a child for success in school is the child's primary caregiver (Beecher & Van Pay, 2020; Cunningham & Zibulsky, 2011). **A caregiver is the child's first and best teacher.** Like all teachers, caregivers know some ways to help their children based on their own experiences and observations, but **they often appreciate guidance in best practices to provide support for school readiness.** That's where you come in! Storytime can be an informal learning environment for the caregivers as well as the children (Neuman, Moland, & Celano, 2017). **Caregivers will learn more from your direct explanations in asides** than from only watching you model school-readiness-boosting strategies (Beecher & Van Pay, 2020). For example, in a survey of caregiver attendees of storytimes in which the librarians were trained to include asides about early literacy, the majority of caregivers reported increases in their knowledge of early literacy skills (Stewart et al., 2014). Share your expertise as you share storytime fun.

Troubleshooting Tips:

- If you're worried that you're not knowledgeable enough about school readiness or that you'll sound judgmental, you're not alone. Some of the librarians we interviewed and librarians in other studies (Neuman, Moland, & Celano, 2017; Stewart et al., 2014) shared these worries about delivering asides. You're already taking a step to overcoming the first worry by reading this guide! You can talk to caregivers about the strategies you're trying, sharing while you explore and learn. Overcome the second worry by practicing your wording ahead of time so that you sound more informative than instructional. To avoid saying things like "you should," prepare phrasing such as "I like to [strategy] because [reason/way it promotes school readiness]" or "When we [strategy], we're promoting [aspect of school readiness] because [reason/way it promotes school readiness]." For example, "I like to ask children why a solution worked in the book because it promotes problem-solving skills."
- Experiment to find wording that feels comfortable for you. You might choose a form of address to alert the caregivers that you're talking directly to them—"caregivers," "adults," "grown-ups," "friends," etc. You can call the aside an early literacy tip, a take-home tip, a "try this at home" idea, a school readiness strategy, etc.
- Pair giving an aside with an element you already always include in your storytime routine. The most obvious choice is with the first book you read aloud; pair saying the book's title and author with saying your aside.
- Make a visual aid to remember your aside. Put a sticky note on the book you're sharing or on the container of materials for an activity or craft. Add a note to the slide presentation or other technology you use to display song lyrics.

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

Path 5: Strategies to Promote and Deliver Storytimes to Diverse Groups

5.1: What We Looked At

5.2: Why It Matters

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5.4: What You Can Do

5.4.1: Advertise and Address Timing-Related Barriers

5.4.2: Focus on Support for Historically Underserved Groups

5.4.3: Learn More from Online Sources

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5.1: What We Looked At

We distributed surveys to the caregivers who attended the 68 storytime sessions we observed at 35 libraries. A total of 346 caregivers responded. In addition to the question about caregiver's reasons for storytime attendance, the survey asked caregivers what barriers to attendance they might face as well as how they heard about the storytime program.

We also conducted an online survey of public library directors across the United States which had 698 respondents. Directors used a 5-point scale to rate the relative importance of a given set of storytime objectives, outcomes and outputs, and supports and inputs.

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5.2: Why It Matters

Public libraries have the resources and opportunity to join with families, schools, and other community agencies to promote early literacy and school readiness among all members of a community (Young et al., 2019). Although truly serving diverse groups has historically been a challenge for public libraries, librarians continue to face this challenge and adapt resources, services, and programs to address the needs and interests of all community members (American Library Association, 2018).

The opinions of caregivers who already attend storytimes can give insights into what elements of storytime may attract other caregivers as well as what barriers may be preventing the attendance of other caregivers in the community. The findings from our survey of library directors may be particularly helpful to you in promoting and delivering storytimes to diverse groups because understanding how library directors across the country perceive storytime may help you communicate the value of your storytimes to your own library director and to gain your director's support in making improvements to marketing and outreach efforts.

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5.3: What We Learned

Here are some highlights from the findings of the caregiver surveys.

- Caregivers newer to attending storytime placed great value on the fact that storytimes are free and on the opportunity for their children to socialize with other children.
- Some caregivers (19%) reported that the child's schedule (falls during naptime/snack time, etc.) could be a barrier to attending storytime. The majority of the respondents (37%) chose "Other" for the barrier question, and the majority of these noted timing-related barriers such as being a working parent or another family member's conflicting schedule.
- The top four ways caregivers found out about a storytime program they attended were a friend's recommendation (24%), the library's website (25%), a library advertisement (22%), and a librarian's recommendation (17%).

These findings are the basis for our recommended strategies to promote and deliver storytimes in ways that overcome barriers, adapt marketing promotions based on what's already working, and attempt to reach previously underserved groups in your community.

In survey responses, a majority of library directors gave a high importance rating to the outcome that storytime programs can attract patrons from diverse groups in the community who may not otherwise visit the library. Many directors also highly rated the objectives that storytimes "provide a safe place for children to engage in play" and "provide a space for child caregivers/parents to interact socially." These ratings support the view of the library as a space for community engagement.

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SECTION OVERVIEW

5.4: What You Can Do

5.4.1: Advertise and Address Timing-Related Barriers

5.4.2: Focus on Support for Historically Underserved Groups

5.4.3: Learn More from Online Sources

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5.4.1: Advertise and Address Timing-Related Barriers

Add to Advertising

Whether your library uses posters, flyers, emails, postcards, a website, social media, the radio, text messages, or some combination thereof to advertise storytimes, here are some ideas you can add to make your program stand out.

- Highlight that the storytime is free.
- Include photos (taken with a guardian's consent at a library program) of children interacting with one another and/or with a caregiver – showing caregivers storytimes can provide the socializing they desire for their children.
- Emphasize that library storytimes are a place for kids to have fun while actively learning (rather than a place where children will be shhh-ed and told to sit still).
- Include ways storytimes help children get ready to read and get ready to succeed in school as well as *empower caregivers* to help children get ready to read and get ready to succeed in school.
- State that storytimes welcome all children who want to be there with space and opportunities for all to enjoy and learn.

Address Timing-Related Barriers

Provide storytime sessions on a weekday evening and/or on a weekend day.

- If it isn't feasible to add a weekly storytime to the schedule, you could try to change or add one a month that takes place at a non-typical time.
- Three main strategies that libraries have successfully used to provide evening and weekend storytime programs are: adjusting staff schedules, adding more staff, and collaborating with outside presenters and/or trained volunteers (Hughes-Hassel, Agosto, & Sun, 2007).

Give a brief survey to caregivers of young children who visit the branch but do not attend storytime to identify possible alternate times and/or other barriers that are preventing them from attending storytime.

Consider partnering with a community organization such as a recreation center or local parks department to present a storytime at another location that can facilitate access outside of regular library hours or school hours.

Convert an existing toddler- or preschooler-focused storytime into an “All Ages” or “Family” storytime so that caregivers may bring multiple children.

Provide alternatives to in-person programming.

Record virtual storytimes that can be available on your library's website or social media pages 24/7 or, if technology allows, schedule live virtual storytime events that families can attend in the evening or on weekends. Resources for **virtual storytimes** include:

- The Association for Library Service to Children, Colorado Libraries for Early Literacy, and other professionals collaborated to make an online Virtual Storytime Services Guide available at <http://www.ala.org/alsc/virtual-storytime-services-resource-guide>. Topics covered by this guide include technology, copyright, and diversity.
- Network of the National Library of Medicine [NNLM] have made the hour-long webinar “Virtual Programs for Preschoolers: How to Encourage Wellness, Movement & Creativity” presented by Katie Clausen available at <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ufasFHHdBB8>.

You could also provide storytime kits that are either circulating or one-time use. Storytime kits can contain many materials but the common goal is that caregivers can use one to recreate the storytime experience at home. In addition to books, a storytime kit might contain song lyrics, activity directions, puppets, puzzles, and felt pieces. Resources for **storytime kits** include:

- The NWT Literacy Council created a guide for how you can create your own type of storytime kit that circulates called Storysacks: https://www.nwtliteracy.ca/sites/default/files/resources/storysac_0.pdf.
- The Early Childhood Resource Center has a type of circulating storytime kit called Sprout Early Learning Backpacks. These are available to purchase at <https://www.ecresourcecenter.org/wba/content/community/sprout-learning-backpacks/> or you can get

ideas for building similar kits of your own by looking at the pictures of each kit at

<https://www.ecresourcecenter.org/CMSFiles/ECRC/files/file/sproutbackpacksb.pdf>.

- Hatch Public Library (Wisconsin) provides digital resources for themed storytime kits with four parts: Read an ebook or audiobook, Sing with a video from YouTube, Make a simple craft from directions on a website, Explore more about the theme with a kid-friendly website or online directions for an activity. Take a look at the kits here <https://www.hatchpubliclibrary.org/storytime-kits.html> for inspiration.
- For ideas for creating a monthly one-time-use storytime kit, check out the Early Literacy-To-Go kits created by a children's librarian and described in the blog Adventures in Storytime (and Beyond): <http://www.adventuresinstorytime.com/search/label/Early%20Literacy-To-Go%20Kits>.

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5.4.2: Focus on Support for Historically Underserved Groups

As you think about developing your storytime strategies, consider all the communities your library serves and how some groups may have been historically underserved by your library. These groups may include working caregivers, teen caregivers, families experiencing homelessness, caregivers in recovery programs, families who speak a native language other than English or are English language learners, or families with children with differing abilities or cognitive differences. One overall strategy many librarians have found to be effective is to collaborate with a local agency such as a health department, recreation center, or nonprofit organization that is already serving members of the community you wish to better serve (Arnold, 2002; Campana, Mills, & Martin, 2018; Martinez, 2008). Another general strategy is to design storytimes with the expectation that every caregiver has valuable knowledge and experiences to share. As one early childhood specialist, Renea Arnold (2002) explains, “A partnership can develop only when we acknowledge that parents and caregivers can be skilled, knowledgeable, experienced, and active contributors to children’s development. We expect to exchange information with them and consider their opinions. This establishes reciprocity in the relationship, with parents and caregivers contributing as well as receiving services” (p. 25). In addition to these general strategies, here are a few ideas for promoting and delivering storytimes to a specific underserved group.

Working Caregivers

A common barrier for working caregivers is time, so consider using strategies from the [Addressing Timing-Related Barriers](#) sections of this guide.

Advertise your storytimes as specifically beneficial to caregivers for learning how to support their child’s school readiness. Our surveys showed that many caregivers are already interested in these benefits for their children. Working caregivers who have limited time with their children may be especially interested in a program that promises both entertainment and education.

Consider ways to give caregivers and their children ways to take an active role during the storytime. For example, the key to the success of a monthly reading program, Ramos and Vila (2015) report, was that the participants were given opportunities to choose upcoming program themes and to share the reading activities they had done at home between meetings.

Families Who Speak a Native Language Other than English; Families Who Are English Language Learners

Are you monolingual but also interested in presenting bilingual or multilingual storytimes? Some scholars suggest the best practice is to only have fluent speakers present storytime. This is because the presenter should be able to easily interact with the children and talk to caregivers who may have questions about the program, the library, or their child’s literacy and learning (Payne & Ralli, 2017). However, there are plenty of ways to make your current storytimes welcoming to speakers of all languages, whether or not you choose to facilitate an entire storytime in a language other than English.

- Use online resources to mix in videos of songs and book read alouds in languages other than English.
- Learn how to say simple conversational phrases, such as hello and goodbye, in three or four languages that are common in your community and use them to welcome families.
- Invite caregivers to share songs and rhymes for children in their native languages with you and then, if they are comfortable and the words are library appropriate, at a later time with the group.
- Practice your pacing. Slow down the pace of your delivery when speaking, reading, singing, and transitioning between activities. Practice speaking with energy and enthusiasm without speaking too fast.
- Display signs with storytime routines translated into multiple languages, when available.
- Try to use common English words and avoid idioms (e.g., “beat around the bush,” “call it a day”).
- Be mindful that people have differing cultural views about eye contact with some avoiding eye contact as a sign of respect and some making eye contact to show respect.

Do you have community members fluent in a language other than English interested in presenting a storytime? This might be a library staff member, a library volunteer, a local college student, or the staff member of another community agency. You could supply them with materials (books, music CDs, etc.), training in storytime best practices, and/or a meeting space at your library to present an additional storytime in that language or in both English and that language. Help them to practice the storytime presentation. Also consider presenting a bilingual storytime.

Do you have a partner (staff member or volunteer) who is interested in presenting a bilingual storytime with you? Adilene Rogers, a seasoned presenter of Spanish and English storytimes, wrote a "[Bilingual Storytime Presenter's Guide](#)" for Jbrary with advice that that is applicable to presenters who speak other languages as well.

Does your library already offer adult programs such as conversational classes for English Language Learners? Schedule a family storytime to take place immediately before or after one of these programs and advertise it alongside the existing program. This may help more families attend both programs – a win-win. However, a logistical point to keep in mind for this strategy is that children may be unattended while adults are in the conversational class. Offering a family storytime that older and younger siblings attend together gives you the opportunity to talk to older siblings about how to help their younger siblings get ready for school through shared reading and conversations during play; this may be especially helpful for families in which an older child or teen is more fluent in English than a caregiver (Terrell & Watson, 2018).

Families of Children with Differing Abilities or Cognitive Differences

It is beneficial for children of all abilities to be able to interact with one another. The concept of natural environments for children with disabilities refers to the idea that these settings should be ones that are typical for a same-aged child without a disability (Early Childhood Technical Assistance Center, n.d.). Creating storytimes that welcome all children shows your support for inclusion and gives families and caregivers options for their children to attend storytime activities.

Librarian Tricia Bohanon (2020) offers these strategies to help refine or transform your space, activities, and attitude to create a safe, welcoming, inclusive, and accommodating environment for children with differing abilities and cognitive differences.

- Allow children to choose their movement, such as standing while you read or sitting while others dance. Prepare the room so that there are places where children can do these movements without preventing others from seeing.
- Say your expectations out loud for the child and their caregiver.
- Understand that not all children show their attention with eye contact or verbal responses.
- Provide a visual agenda for the order of storytime activities.
- Offer adaptive seating such as sitting wedges, Educube chairs, or carpet squares.
- Convert an age-restricted storytime into an “All Ages” or “Family” storytime to welcome individuals whose developmental age is different from their physical age.
- Invest in sensory integration equipment and adaptive technology such as a tactile balance beam, sensory beanbags, weighted snakes and blankets, fidget toys, noise-dampening headphones, and a speech-generating device.
- Include a social time or play period at the end of the program, allowing children, caregivers, and staff to form meaningful connections.
- Market the storytime as an inclusive program – emphasizing that children can be themselves in the library and the library is a community (not a silent!) space.

Also consider this advice from Dr. Tess Prendergast (2015) about creating inclusive storytimes:

- Remember, “Children with disabilities are more like other young children who do not have disabilities than they are different from them” (Prendergast, 2015, p. 188). Therefore, the range of activities you provide in storytime may already be welcoming to most children. However, it’s still important to critically consider your storytime practices and what barriers to involvement they might present to children with different abilities or cognitive differences.
- Slow down the pace of your delivery when speaking, reading, singing, and transitioning between activities. Practice speaking with energy and enthusiasm without speaking too fast.
- Take time to acknowledge each child, remembering that eye contact, smiles, and gestures are ways of showing welcome and encouragement.
- Plan for repetition that gives children multimodal or multisensory ways to interact with key ideas. For example, after reading a story, retell it with puppets or other props, have children act-out part of it, sing a song about a related idea, present a related and interactive app, and/or have children create a craft related to characters or objects from the story. Repetition can take place within one program and across multiple programs to reinforce learning.
- Create a routine so that children can know what to expect in terms of the order of activities. Display the routine with a visual schedule and refer to it as you transition.

- Talk to every child's caregiver about what the child may need in order to get the most out of the program. You don't need to know the child's medical diagnosis and should not ask for it. Building a trusting relationship is the first step, and then you may discuss further strategies and adaptations to increase the child's sense of belonging, participation, and learning during storytime.

Consider contacting the early intervention program specialist in your region. Every state provides early intervention services for children from birth up to age 3 with disabilities and/or developmental delays, but the name of the agency differs across states. Connect with this specialist in order to make them aware of your library's programs and services and to solicit their advice for more ways that you might tailor programs to be more inclusive.

5.4.2: Focus on Support for Historically Underserved Groups is shared under a [not declared](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

5.4.3: Learn More from Online Sources

There are many more ways to promote and deliver storytimes to diverse groups, especially as part of your library's continuing outreach and advocacy efforts. Here are some online sources recommended by Prendergast, Diamant-Cohen, and Goldsmith (2019):

- Ideabook: Libraries for Families - <https://www.packard.org/wp-content/uploads/2017/05/IdeaBook.pdf> - The Public Library Association and the Harvard Family Research Project put together a guide of research-based practices that is easy to search and skim for practical, effective strategies for improving existing programs or building new ones, based on principles of family engagement.
- Reimagining School Readiness Toolkit - <https://bayareadiscoverymuseum.org/resources/educator-resources/library-toolkit> - This toolkit provides a varied set of resources for program improvement strategies connected to findings from a review of research in cognitive and developmental psychology, developed specifically for library staff by the Bay Area Discovery Museum and California State Library's Early Learning with Families initiative.
- Working with Teen Parents at Your Library: Where to Begin - <https://www.alsc.org/blog/2018/08/working-with-teen-parents-at-your-library-where-to-begin/> - Kathryn Woody, a member of the ALSC Library Service to Underserved Children and Their Caregivers committee, provides general strategies as well as descriptions and links to more in-depth resources and examples of successful programs.
- ¡Colorín Colorado! Parent Guide: The Resources at Your Library - <http://www.colorincolorado.org/guide/parent-guide-resources-your-library> - Colin Colorado is a bilingual education site with many research-based professional development resources including a ready-made handout to introduce families to library services and a video with family outreach advice from author and literacy advocate Pat Mora.

An additional resource is the public folder of toolkits created by the Library Service to Underserved Children and Their Caregivers (LSUCTC) committee of ALSC and found at [tinyurl.com/lstuctoolkit](https://www.ala.org/alsc/sites/ala.org.alsc/files/content/professional-tools/lsspcc-toolkit-2015.pdf) or <https://www.ala.org/alsc/sites/ala.org.alsc/files/content/professional-tools/lsspcc-toolkit-2015.pdf> (Leung and Jeffery, 2021). Each toolkit includes three lists: at least five picturebooks recommended for reading aloud, professional resources published recently that provide insights into the underserved population, and relevant community resources (Eastman & Prince, 2021).

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Your Journey Continues...

You have shown your professionalism and care for serving families in your community by learning about one or more research-based ways to enhance your preschool storytimes. We hope you feel inspired and empowered to be a leader in literacy, school readiness, and fun!

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